Bound By Divinity

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/62943904.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
M/M

Fandom:
崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)

Relationship:
Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Characters:
Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Tribbie (Honkai: Star Rail)

Additional Tags:
Succubi & Incubi, Incubus Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Heaven & Hell, Crown Prince Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Fluff and Angst, Comedy, sometimes, Idiots in Love, Rituals, Forbidden Love, My Lousy Attempt At It, Self-Indulgent, like a lot, Sexual Tension, Top Mydei/Bottom Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-02-10 Updated: 2025-05-22 Words: 33,286 Chapters: 6/8

Bound By Divinity

by Lunaeryi

Summary

The Crown Prince of the Heavens is the epitome of divine authority. His incubi familiar? A chaotic mess of teasing, trouble, and far too many bad decisions. Somehow, they make it work.

Notes

Hey y'all, this was meant to be a one shot, but I tested positive for potential TB so lowkey didn't want to write today till I got my imaging back, but I gotta keep you guys updated so uh, give me like a day or two and I'll pump chapter 2 out later, enjoy😭??

Hey but if it sucked ass at least I have an excuse now lol

See the end of the work for more notes

- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: Bound By Divinity/受神性所缚 by YiuBun

Chapter 1: The Prince and The Incubi

Chapter Summary

> Mydei and his incubi familiar as per usual duel, attend some meeting, complete a ritual, and have a totally normal and not caring and soft moment together!

The clash of metal rang through the training hall, a sharp, rhythmic sound that cut through the otherwise silent space. Mydei, Crown Prince of Heaven, moved with precise efficiency, his sword striking with disciplined force. Across from him, Phainon sidestepped effortlessly, dodging each blow with an infuriatingly smooth grace.

“You’re getting predictable, my Prince,” Phainon drawled, smirking as he leaned just out of reach.

Mydei exhaled sharply, his grip tightening on the hilt of his sword. “Focus.”

Phainon grinned. “I am. On you.”

Mydei lunged, and Phainon slipped behind him with a speed that shouldn’t have been possible. A sharp inhale—the feeling of warm breath against his ear—

“You’re stiff today,” Phainon murmured. “Something on your mind?”

Mydei pivoted sharply, but Phainon was already a step ahead, dancing away just out of range. The Incubi’s movements were fluid, teasing, always just brushing the edge of a real fight but never quite engaging seriously. It was infuriating.

“Fight properly,” Mydei snapped.

“But where’s the fun in that?” Phainon countered. He tilted his head, eyes gleaming. “Or are you just frustrated?”

Mydei struck again—faster, more aggressive—but Phainon caught his wrist mid-swing. The sudden proximity sent a spark of irritation down Mydei's spine. Phainon's grip was firm but playful, his fingers lingering just a second too long.

"A prince should be more patient," Phainon mused.

Mydei yanked his arm free. "A familiar should know his place."

Phainon laughed, stepping back with an easy smile. "Oh, I do. Right by your side. Bound to you, after all." His gaze flickered, sharp and knowing. "No escaping me, my Prince."

Mydei turned away before Phainon could see the flicker of frustration in his expression. He sheathed his sword with more force than necessary.

"Training's over," he said curtly, striding toward the exit.

"Already?" Phainon called after him, amusement lacing his tone. "But we were just getting started!"

Mydei didn't look back. He wouldn't give Phainon the satisfaction of seeing how much he'd gotten under his skin.

Summoning an Incubi was never the plan.

Mydei had been prepared for something grander, something befitting the Crown Prince of Heaven. A celestial beast wreathed in divine fire, perhaps, or a guardian carved from the stars themselves. Instead, the summoning circle flared with deep crimson light, shadows twisting unnaturally before coalescing into a figure lounging at its center, all dark silk and lazy arrogance.

Phainon had tilted his head, blue eyes gleaming with mischief as he took in his surroundings—then took in Mydei.

“You’re not what I expected,” Mydei had said, standing rigid, his disappointment carefully masked behind authority.

Phainon had grinned. “Neither are you.”

The binding had been sealed before Mydei could demand another summoning.

That was years ago, and if Phainon had been a thorn in his side then, he was a whole damn briar patch now.

The training hall remained quiet after Mydei’s departure, save for the faint hum of his sheathed sword. Phainon stretched his arms overhead, rolling his shoulders before sauntering after him.

“You’ll hurt yourself if you keep holding tension like that,” he remarked as he fell into step beside Mydei.

“I’ll hurt you if you keep talking,” Mydei replied flatly.

Phainon chuckled. “Empty threats, my Prince. You’d miss me.”

Mydei refused to dignify that with a response.

As they stepped into the open air, golden light poured over the courtyard, painting the pristine marble in warm hues. It should have been a peaceful sight, but Phainon’s presence was anything but. He was always at Mydei’s side, always lingering at the edges of propriety, always testing the limits of his patience.

And yet—despite himself—Mydei had never once considered breaking their bond.

Phainon sighed dramatically, breaking the silence. “What now? More princely duties? Another round of ‘pretend I don’t want to strangle my familiar’?”

Mydei exhaled slowly. “I have a meeting with the Council.”

Phainon wrinkled his nose. “Boring. No wonder you’re tense.”

“Then leave me be.”

Phainon placed a hand over his heart, feigning injury. “Cruel. And after all the time we’ve spent together.”

Mydei barely spared him a glance. “If only it were less.”

Phainon smirked. “Admit it. You’d be lost without me.”

For once, Mydei didn’t answer.

And that, more than anything, made Phainon pause before following.

The council chamber was a grand hall of polished marble and towering columns, bathed in soft celestial light. Its silence was a thing of order, heavy with decorum and the weight of divine governance.

And then there was *Phainon*.

He walked beside Mydei with an easy stride, hands loosely tucked behind his head, humming a tune that had no place in the solemnity of the moment. It was a lazy, almost mocking melody, and it did not stop even as they reached the massive doors of the chamber, where two armored sentinels bowed deeply to their Crown Prince.

Phainon winked at them in passing.

Mydei exhaled sharply through his nose. “Must you?”

“Oh? Did you have a song preference?” Phainon asked, tilting his head. “Perhaps something more regal? I could try a ballad—”

“Phainon.”

Phainon grinned. “Fine, fine. I’ll be good.”

Mydei doubted that.

The doors opened, revealing the assembled council—elders of wisdom and power, each draped in flowing robes of celestial white and gold. They turned as one to greet their prince, their expressions serene and composed. But as Phainon strolled in after him, humming louder now, that composure visibly strained.

A few narrowed their eyes. One elder sighed deeply, already resigned. Another, the High Minister, clasped his hands together with long-suffering patience.

“My Prince,” the High Minister greeted, ignoring Phainon entirely. “We are honored by your presence.”

Phainon leaned in slightly. “And mine?”

No one answered.

Mydei sat at the head of the chamber, back straight, gaze firm. Phainon, rather than standing respectfully behind him, leaned against the side of the chair, close enough that Mydei could feel his presence like an ember at his shoulder.

The meeting began. Reports were given on celestial defenses, divine laws, and the state of the heavenly realms. Mydei listened, responding where needed, every bit the composed ruler he was trained to be. And through it all, Phainon *remained*.

He played with a lock of Mydei’s hair at one point.

Mydei caught his wrist without looking.

Phainon smirked. “Distracting, am I?”

“Do you have a death wish?”

“Would you deliver it personally?”

Mydei tightened his grip slightly before letting go. Phainon chuckled, unfazed, and settled beside him with the ease of someone who had long

since claimed his place at Mydei's side—whether anyone liked it or not.

The council endured his presence, but as the meeting drew to a close, the High Minister finally addressed the matter.

"My Prince," he began delicately, "may I suggest that *certain company* is perhaps… inappropriate for discussions of such importance?"

Phainon feigned a gasp. "Oh, *certain company*? That wouldn't be me, would it?"

"Phainon," Mydei warned.

The Incubi sighed. "Fine, fine. You wound me, Minister, truly. But if you insist, I'll leave the boring talks to you." He pushed off the chair and stretched, unbothered. "I'll be outside, my Prince. Don't miss me too much."

With that, he sauntered out, humming again—louder than before.

The council chamber fell into relieved silence.

Mydei pinched the bridge of his nose.

The High Minister cleared his throat. "He remains… an unconventional choice, Your Highness."

Tell me something I don't know.

But Mydei only straightened, voice calm. "He is bound to me. That is not something I can change."

Nor something, he realized, that he *would* change.

Not anymore.

The moment the council meeting ended, Mydei's body seemed to deflate, his posture shifting from that of a crown prince to someone who had just survived an exhausting ordeal. He stepped out of the grand chamber and

into the courtyard, the warm light of the celestial sun bathing the marble in golden hues.

He barely got a step in before he saw *him*.

Phainon was sprawled across the steps leading to the royal gardens, one leg casually thrown over the other, an arm draped across his eyes as though he were taking an afternoon nap.

“Oh, for the love of—” Mydei muttered under his breath.

Phainon didn’t even flinch at his approach, instead raising his voice in a dramatic drawl. “Ah, my Prince. How was the *delightful* council? Was it everything you dreamed of?”

“Do you really have to do this now?” Mydei bit out, eyes narrowing as he stepped closer.

Phainon peeled his arm from his face and grinned up at him, eyes gleaming. “Oh, don’t be so serious, Mydei. Life is far too short for that.” He sat up slowly, stretching as if he were waking from a luxurious slumber. “I, for one, think you were *dazzling* in there. All that authority… so many *important* words. I was *enthralled*.”

“Mm-hmm,” Mydei muttered, the sarcasm grating at him. “And what are you doing?”

Phainon smiled lazily. “What do you mean? *I’m resting*.” He looked pointedly at the intricate celestial statues surrounding the garden, his gaze lingering on a particularly grand one of a fallen star warrior. “I find it quite *peaceful* here. These statues have such character.”

Mydei followed his gaze and immediately regretted it. Phainon was draped over one of the statues in a completely inappropriate manner—his hand was resting on the statue’s base, and he looked like he was about to start a conversation with it.

“I swear, Phainon,” Mydei began, a headache already forming at his temples. “I *will* have you removed from every sacred space if you don’t stop.”

Phainon just shrugged, flashing him that wicked grin. “Oh, *please*. The statues *love* me. I’m giving them a little company, a bit of entertainment. They’ve been standing here for centuries, after all. What’s a few more years of me lounging around?”

Mydei rubbed the bridge of his nose in frustration. “You *always* find a way to make a mess of things.”

“Mess?” Phainon leaned back with an exaggerated pout. “I’m bringing a little life to the place, is all.” He gave a theatrical glance around. “Would you rather I be bored?”

Before Mydei could respond, Phainon was on his feet again, brushing himself off with exaggerated care. “But I suppose I should stop before you decide to get *angry* with me again. Wouldn’t want to see that pretty little scowl of yours.” He winked.

Mydei made a noise in the back of his throat, too tired to argue. “Let’s go. I have other matters to attend to.”

Phainon fell into step beside him without question, his hum now quieter but still there, like an echo of something much too carefree for the moment. “You know, you’re lucky you’ve got me. Life would be so boring without me.”

Mydei glanced at him, too weary to argue, and almost smiled despite himself. “I don’t know about that.”

“Oh, come now,” Phainon teased, nudging him playfully. “You’d miss me if I wasn’t here.”

Mydei sighed, already walking faster, but Phainon kept pace effortlessly. “Keep dreaming, Phainon.”

“I do.” Phainon grinned. “Every day.”

The Elysian Gardens were peaceful as always, a serene escape from the political turmoil of the celestial courts. Lush greenery spread across the grounds, and intricate stone pathways wove through towering statues of fallen warriors and celestial beings. The air was filled with the scent of blooming flowers, and the soft sounds of birds echoed in the distance.

Mydei strolled through the gardens, the thoughts of his responsibilities and duties he’d have to take care of today heavy on his shoulders, though his stride was steady and controlled. He often came here to clear his mind, finding solace in the solitude—or at least, he used to.

Today, however, the quiet was interrupted by the sound of small, hesitant footsteps. Looking down, Mydei spotted a young child standing before him, eyes wide with curiosity. The child was dressed in fine garments that indicated their noble lineage, the sigil of a visiting dignitary’s house embroidered on the chest.

“My Prince,” the child said with a polite bow, though they were clearly unsure of how to approach. “I—I hope I’m not disturbing you.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow, but the level of formality in the child’s voice seemed to soften his usual reserve. “Not at all,” he replied smoothly, though his tone was still that of someone unused to children’s presence. “What brings you to the Gardens?”

The child hesitated but then looked up at him with bright eyes. “My mother says I must be on my best behavior while here, but… I wanted to ask if you’d let me braid your hair.”

Mydei blinked, caught off guard by the request. He wasn’t particularly used to such boldness from anyone, let alone a child. His hand instinctively brushed a few strands of hair behind his ear as if checking if it were in disarray.

“I’m afraid my hair is not meant for such things,” Mydei said, his voice still calm but with the barest hint of reluctance.

Phainon, who had been leaning casually against a nearby pillar, watched with an amused glint in his eyes. “I think it could use a little fun,” he mused, loud enough for Mydei to hear but not addressing him directly. “What’s a little braid between you and royalty?”

Mydei shot Phainon a glance but said nothing in reply, his focus still on the child, who looked up at him expectantly.

“Well, if you truly wish,” Mydei said finally, his voice softening just enough to convey that he wasn’t entirely against the idea, “I’ll allow you a single braid. But do it quickly. I have duties to attend to.”

The child’s face lit up with joy, and before Mydei could change his mind, they hurried to his side, gathering the strands of his hair with surprising skill. Mydei stood still, his gaze scanning the serene beauty of the gardens, though his posture remained as composed as ever. He made no move to stop the child, though a hint of amusement flickered in his eyes as the braid slowly took shape.

Phainon couldn’t help but chuckle from his spot by the pillar, arms crossed. “Well, I never thought I’d see the day,” he said, more to himself than to anyone. “The mighty Crown Prince of Heaven…allowing his hair to be braided so willfully, by a child no less.”

Mydei didn’t respond, though the corner of his mouth twitched ever so slightly. The child, oblivious to the underlying tension between the two, hummed softly as they worked, clearly delighted by the opportunity.

Phainon leaned in slightly, his smirk widening. “You know, I could do an even better braid if you’d let me.”

Mydei finally turned his head just enough to fix Phainon with a warning glare. “Don’t push your luck.”

Phainon grinned but held up his hands in mock surrender. “Fine, fine. I’ll let the kid have this victory.”

The child finished tying off the braid with a small ribbon from their sleeve and stepped back, beaming with pride. “There! Now you look even more regal, Your Highness!”

Mydei reached up, fingers brushing over the braid, his expression unreadable. “Hmph,” was all he said, but the sharp edges of his usual demeanor seemed to soften, just a little.

Phainon tilted his head, watching Mydei with something unreadable in his own gaze. “Well, well,” he murmured. “Would you look at that.”

Mydei ignored him. “Go on now,” he told the child, his voice gentler than before. “Your mother will be looking for you.”

The child bowed deeply before scampering off, leaving Mydei standing in the sunlight, the single braid a quiet testament to the rare moment of indulgence.

Phainon, watching him closely, smiled—not in his usual teasing way, but something quieter, something thoughtful.

“Regal, huh?” he mused, mostly to himself.

Mydei finally turned his attention back to him. “Not a word,” he warned.

Phainon merely chuckled, falling into step beside him as they left the gardens. “Oh, my Prince,” he drawled, eyes twinkling with mischief. “This is going to haunt you forever.”

Mydei didn’t disagree with that.

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Okhema was a city of light. That was its virtue, its pride—stone kissed by divinity, prayers woven into the air itself. It reeked of sanctity, the scent

cloying, thick, and layered with something sickly sweet to Phainon's senses. He hated it. He loved it.

If there was ever a place that tempted corruption, it was this one.

Phainon walked a step behind Mydei, not because he was obligated to but because it was safer that way. The prince strode through the marble streets with the same cold poise as always, indifferent to the awed and reverent gazes that followed him. People whispered in his wake, hands pressed to their chests in respect. Here, Mydei was seen as a celestial force, a prince of the divine. Phainon, trailing behind him, felt like something dredged up from the dark.

It thrilled him.

He grinned, tongue sliding over his teeth, catching the sharp points. No one here knew. No one understood what he was, what he could do if he wanted to. The weight of devotion, the raw emotion that saturated the air, made his skin hum, his hunger twisting deep in his core. It was a slow, aching pulse, something he had mastered the art of ignoring. But here, in Okhema, where desire was wrapped in faith, where people surrendered themselves so easily to something greater than them—Phainon could barely breathe.

He should leave.

He wouldn't.

Not when Mydei moved like that, purposeful and untouchable, his presence cutting through the city's purity like a blade. Phainon's fingers twitched. He wanted to touch him, wanted to press up against him just to feel if that unwavering composure would crack, if Mydei's pulse would jump beneath his palm. The thought sent a slow, molten curl of something wicked through him.

"Behave yourself," Mydei said suddenly, not looking back.

Phainon chuckled, low and dark. "What am I doing?"

“You’re thinking too loudly.”

That was dangerous. But then again, so was he.

They passed a group of acolytes kneeling in prayer, their lips moving in soft, reverent murmurs. Phainon’s gaze dragged over them, lingering where robes dipped, where skin flushed from the midday heat. He could taste it, the hints of want buried beneath devotion. It would be so easy. Just a touch. A whisper. The right kind of temptation, and they’d fall into his hands like ripe fruit.

A sharp, silent warning cut through his thoughts—Mydei’s fingers brushing against his wrist, a fleeting, deliberate touch. Phainon inhaled sharply, heat curling low in his gut. Mydei didn’t even glance at him.

“Don’t test me,” the prince murmured.

Phainon exhaled, laughter caught somewhere between frustration and delight. “Never.”

Liar.

The night deepened, and Okhema’s nightlife hummed softly, distant murmurs drifting on the breeze as Mydei and Phainon ventured into the quieter, darker corners of the city. The streets here carried an unsettling silence, as though even the air itself was holding its breath. It was in this eerie stillness that Phainon’s restraint, already frayed by the weight of the city, finally unraveled.

Mydei halted before an ancient temple, its golden doors etched with intricate, divine patterns. He turned to Phainon, his tone as steady as ever. “We’ll be staying here for the night. I need time to—”

But Phainon was already moving. His expression shifted, no longer the playful tease, but something darker, something far more dangerous. He hadn’t meant to—hadn’t planned it—but Okhema’s intoxicating pull, its

suffocating devotion, the way every breath seemed heavy with emotion… He couldn't stand it any longer.

He turned to face Mydei, his eyes burning with a hunger that was impossible to disguise now. The teasing, the games, all fell away. "Do you feel it, Mydei?" His voice dropped to a low rasp, dangerous and charged with a potency that seemed to vibrate through the very air. "This city… the way it calls to us. How easy it would be to lose ourselves in it. *If you let me."*

Mydei froze, sensing the shift immediately. It wasn't his Phainon anymore. No, the darkness that had always lurked beneath the surface was creeping out, his true nature slipping through, thick and primal.

Phainon closed the distance between them, each step deliberate, the tension thickening in the air. His breath, warm and insistent, brushed against Mydei's skin, and Mydei's pulse jumped. It felt like the world had narrowed to just the two of them, the space between them charged with something too dangerous to name. Phainon leaned in, his lips grazing the delicate shell of Mydei's ear. "I could give you what you truly desire," he whispered, the words heavy with promise, but also a subtle, threatening edge.

For a moment, the distance between them seemed to collapse entirely. Phainon's presence enveloped Mydei, making the air feel suffocating, taut with unspoken things. His lips were so close, his body too near, and yet the words hung there, the invitation impossible to ignore.

But Mydei wasn't one to easily fall prey to temptation, especially not when he knew just how deep this pull was, how dangerous. His hand shot out, seizing Phainon's wrist with a force that was almost violent. "*Enough*."

The word sliced through the thick tension, and in that moment, the air seemed to snap—like the stillness of the night had been cracked open by something primal.

The chill of the night seemed to sharpen as Phainon stepped back, his breath coming unevenly. He hadn't meant to lose control—not like this, not

in front of Mydei. His usual confidence faltered, but he wasn't about to grovel. He simply… regretted it.

"I'm sorry," he said, his voice steady but carrying a faint undercurrent of something darker—shaken at the unusual loss of control, but not broken. "I crossed a line."

His eyes remained fixed on the ground, avoiding Mydei's gaze. The last thing he needed was to see the prince's reaction, to read something in his eyes that would drag him back into that maddening pull.

Mydei stood still, silent. It was almost unbearable. The air between them hummed with unspoken thoughts, yet no words followed.

Phainon took a slow breath, his hands curling into fists at his sides, forcing himself to remain composed. "I'll… keep my distance." The words hung there, an offering and an apology in one.

The silence stretched on. For a moment, it felt like everything was held in suspension—the tension thickening with every passing second, both of them feeling it, but neither willing to speak further.

Mydei finally spoke, his voice quiet, but clear. "Don't make promises you can't keep."

Phainon's jaw tightened, and for a moment, he considered turning away, leaving, but the thought vanished as quickly as it came. He couldn't leave Mydei here, not like this. With a sharp exhale, he followed a few paces behind the prince, his gaze still lowered, keeping a respectful distance. His thoughts churned, and the fire that had sparked in him earlier was now buried deep beneath layers of control.

Mydei kept walking, unfazed, but Phainon could sense that the prince was aware of the shift, the uncomfortable tension that had settled in.

Phainon's hands curled tighter into fists at his sides as he followed, keeping his distance but not leaving. He'd stay with Mydei, no matter the silence.

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The golden doors of the temple loomed ahead, opening with an unsettling creak. Inside, the air was heavy with incense and the quiet hum of prayers. The flickering light of candles danced on the walls, casting long shadows, and at the far end of the temple stood the Tribios—Tribbie, Trianne, and Trinnon—waiting patiently.

As always, they resembled children despite their age, their features perfectly identical, and their strange mannerisms further evoking that childlike innocence. They wore pale robes that fluttered like the wings of ghosts, and their eyes, sharp yet innocent, glimmered as Mydei entered.

“Dei,” they chorused in unison, their voices as sweet as they were eerie. “We’ve been expecting you.”

Phainon, ever the observer, leaned casually against one of the marble pillars, arms crossed, a grin tugging at the corner of his lips as he watched them. The Tribios always had this effect on him—he could never bring himself to act teasingly with them. They reminded him too much of younger siblings, and in turn, he was incredibly endeared by their antics. They had a way of making him feel simultaneously grounded and unsettled.

“You’re late,” Tribbie remarked, her eyes flicking over to Phainon. “We’ve been waiting for both of you. Snowy…” She trailed off, a small smirk forming as she looked at him.

Phainon’s eyes sparkled with mischief. “I wasn’t the one holding us up,” he said with mock indignation. “Mydei’s busy being all important and princely.”

Mydei shot Phainon a half-glare, but Phainon only winked in return. He could never resist teasing, especially when it came to Mydei. The air between them was always ripe for it.

“Don’t make this harder than it is,” Mydei muttered under his breath, clearly not amused.

The Tribios exchanged a glance, their childlike giggles echoing softly in the temple. “We have a ritual tonight,” Trianne said, stepping forward with an unsettling grace. “A purification, a cleansing of the soul. It will require you both to focus and trust in the process.”

Phainon raised an eyebrow, his grin widening. “Purification, huh?” His tone was light, but there was an edge to it. He was, after all, an Incubi—temptation was his domain. “What’s the catch? No getting possessed or anything, right?” He said this as if he hasn’t gone through it thousand of times.

The Tribios smiled serenely, unfazed by his sarcasm, and indulging him. “No catch. Only your trust. You will be tested—both of you.”

Phainon’s gaze flickered to Mydei, who appeared unperturbed as always. Mydei might be the one in charge of the kingdom, but in here, in Okhema’s sacred space, even he had to abide by the temple’s rules.

Phainon pushed himself off the pillar, his grin still present but his voice quieter. “All right, let’s see what you’ve got for us.” His teasing demeanor remained, but there was a flicker of curiosity, a desire to see what this ritual would reveal.

The Tribios nodded, and with a swish of their robes, they moved to prepare the ritual space. Phainon and Mydei stood at the center, the air thick with an energy that Phainon could almost taste.

“Ready for this?” Phainon murmured to Mydei, not looking at him but at the silent preparation in front of them.

Mydei gave a slight nod. “We don’t have much choice, do we?”

Phainon chuckled lightly. “I’m just wondering what kind of trouble I’m going to get into.” He then turned his gaze toward the Tribios, eyes glinting with amusement. “Lead the way, kids.”

Despite his playful tone, there was an underlying wariness to his posture. He was more attuned to the strange, dark energy swirling around them than

Mydei was. But for now, he stayed silent, watching the Tribios prepare for the ritual was about to take place.

Despite the playful banter, there was a subtle wariness to Phainon's posture. His body was on alert, attuned to the strange, unsettling energy that seemed to cling to the air around them. He could feel it—the tension in the very air, the sacred power of purification that would soon course through the temple. While Mydei remained mostly unaffected, Phainon felt every pulse of that energy like a whisper to his very core.

The ritual wasn't something he wanted to endure, but it was part of his bond with Mydei. As his familiar, Phainon had to be present, had to endure the process alongside the prince. It wasn't just tradition—it was a requirement. One that would leave him weakened and vulnerable, but still, it was necessary. If Phainon wanted to remain bound to Mydei, he couldn't refuse this. Not even for his own sanity.

He stayed silent as the Tribios began their preparations, the young high priests moving with practiced ease, their small forms somehow radiating an aura of ancient power. Phainon's eyes darted between them and the temple's vast, hallowed walls, his mind focused on the ritual about to unfold. Despite his lighthearted remarks, his body tensed with anticipation. This would be painful. And the aftermath? Far worse.

But for Mydei, Phainon would endure it—no matter how much it cost him.

The temple was silent, save for the soft hum of the Tribios' chant. The air grew heavier with each passing second, saturated with a divine energy that burned like fire and pressed down like stone. The purification was already beginning. The golden light around them flickered, intense and sharp. It was a force that Phainon would never become accustomed to, one that seared through his very being. And Mydei knew it.

Phainon had long since given up pretending to be unaffected. He clenched his jaw, his hands trembling as he fought to stay on his feet. He could feel the burn starting deep in his chest, the way the light tugged at his soul, trying to rid him of everything that made him what he was. The purity it demanded was something that could never be his. Not entirely.

The Tribios' voices rose in unison, their words creating a sonic web of divinity that crushed down on Phainon's mind. The light enveloped him, and every nerve in his body screamed in protest. But even as his limbs began to tremble, even as his vision blurred and his breath came in ragged gasps, Phainon refused to let himself collapse. Not in front of Mydei.

The prince, standing beside him, was silent but tense, his gaze fixed on Phainon with an expression that was equal parts concern and something darker, guilt mingling with helplessness. Mydei's fingers twitched, as if reaching for Phainon, but he didn't move. He knew what the ritual demanded. He knew what it cost Phainon. Yet there was nothing he could do to stop it.

"You know this is necessary," Mydei said quietly, his voice threaded with remorse, but resolute. "For both of us."

Phainon could barely hear him over the deafening pulse of divine energy, but the words cut through nonetheless. His lips curled into something that could have been a smile, but it was more a grimace. "Necessary… sure," he rasped. "But I never said I liked it."

Mydei winced, the guilt deepening in his chest. He knew. He could feel it—the suffering Phainon was enduring. The prince had seen it too many times over the centuries. Every time the purification took place, he had to watch as his familiar was burned from the inside out, his demonic essence stripped away by the purity of the ritual. It left Phainon weakened, barely able to stand, and it never failed to eat away at Mydei's insides. But it had to be done.

The Tribios continued their chant, and Phainon's body buckled slightly under the strain. His breath was shallow, but he held his ground. It was almost unbearable. He could feel his essence crumbling under the weight of the holy light, his incubi nature fighting back, desperately trying to resist.

"Stay with me, Snowy," Mydei murmured, his voice low, almost pleading, but his eyes never left Phainon's face. The prince wasn't sure if he was speaking to Phainon for reassurance or for himself.

Phainon swallowed hard, his eyes flickering as he forced his gaze up to Mydei, offering him a half-hearted grin. “What, you think I’m going to collapse in front of you?” His voice was weak, strained, but there was something about his bravado that made Mydei’s heart tighten in his chest.

“I know you’re strong,” Mydei said, barely louder than a whisper. “But I also know how much this hurts.”

It wasn’t long before the ritual reached its apex. The Tribios’ voices blended into a single, resonant note, and Phainon couldn’t hold back anymore. His knees buckled under the intensity, and his chest heaved in ragged breaths. He felt as if he were being torn apart, his very identity sundered by the light. His head spun, his vision darkening at the edges, and he could taste the metallic tang of blood in his mouth.

Finally, the ritual ended. The light receded, leaving Phainon trembling in its wake. His body, frail and exhausted, was barely able to stand, but he did—barely. His head lolled to the side, sweat dripping down his brow, and his breath came in shallow gasps.

The Tribios stepped back, their eyes shining with satisfaction, and they muttered something in unison that Phainon couldn’t catch. He was barely aware of them now, his senses dulling. The ritual had stripped him of everything that made him who he was, and he felt exposed, vulnerable.

But the worst part was that Mydei had watched it all.

Without another word, Mydei moved toward Phainon, his hand gently but firmly guiding him away from the center of the ritual. The Tribios stepped aside as the prince passed, their faces unreadable, but their gazes following them with a silent intensity. Despite their childlike appearances, there was something ancient and knowing about the way they watched the pair leave.

“Take care of him, Dei,” Tribbie called softly, her voice a blend of innocence and something far older.

“We hope the journey is kinder to you, Snowy,” Trianne added, her tone carrying a note of quiet concern.

Trinnon gave a faint nod, but said nothing, his amber eyes lingering on Phainon with a strange, solemn air.

Mydei didn’t reply to them. He simply nodded, acknowledging their presence before guiding Phainon out of the temple. The air outside was colder than it had been inside, and the night pressed in with its silence as they left the ritual chamber behind. Phainon leaned heavily on Mydei, every step a struggle, though he didn’t protest.

“Mydei…” Phainon murmured, his voice strained. He tried to push himself upright, but the effort was futile. “I’ll be fine.” It was the same line he always said, even when he knew it wasn’t true.

Mydei didn’t respond, but his grip tightened on Phainon’s arm. His expression was unreadable, though the way his jaw tightened suggested something darker was stirring beneath the surface. He didn’t need to say it out loud—the guilt that always followed these rituals hung between them, suffocating and unspoken.

Phainon, exhausted and trembling, was too worn to speak. His mind drifted, the pain from the ritual lingering, gnawing at him. But Mydei was here. Mydei always was.

They passed through the temple doors, the cool night air cutting against Phainon’s flushed skin, offering a brief sense of relief from the suffocating pain. But that relief was fleeting, and the tremors in Phainon’s body only deepened as the ritual’s effects lingered. Mydei glanced at him, his fingers tightening on Phainon’s arm in silent reassurance.

“We’ll get you some rest,” Mydei said, his voice low and determined. “Just a little longer.”

Phainon didn’t reply. There was no need to. Mydei always took care of him when this happened—whether Phainon liked it or not.

Mydei’s grip on Phainon tightened as the exhausted Incubi leaned heavily on him. The tremors running through Phainon were a cruel reminder of

what he had just endured. Each step was labored, but Mydei didn’t rush him. He had seen this before. He had done this before.

“Just hold on a little longer,” Mydei murmured, his voice soft but firm, though his eyes betrayed the guilt that had followed him for centuries.

Phainon could barely register the words, his body too worn to care. His mind was foggy, his senses dulled by the pain. But his instincts, his hunger, they were already starting to wake up.

They reached a secluded part of the city, away from the watchful eyes of the temple, the cold night air pressing in on them. Mydei’s pace slowed as they approached a stone archway hidden in the shadows.

“This way,” Mydei said quietly, his voice barely above a whisper as he guided Phainon forward. The air around them thickened, a palpable sense of magic swirling in the air. Mydei’s blood pulsed beneath his skin—its signature was unmistakable. This was the passage, a thin seam between dimensions, a place neither here nor there, where time twisted and reality bent.

Phainon, his gaze unfocused and hazy, took in the dark archway, sensing something familiar but distant in the air.

“You know this place,” Mydei said with a small sigh, the words more to himself than to Phainon. “This is where you go after. Where you always go.”

Phainon’s eyes flickered, barely registering his words. The hunger inside him was too loud, too demanding.

Mydei, in a practiced motion, pricked his own finger with a small, delicate blade. Blood pooled at the tip, dark and thick, and he pressed it against the stone, muttering words in a language Phainon couldn’t quite place. The air rippled as the passage opened, a tear in the fabric of reality itself.

Without a word, Mydei led Phainon through.

The world on the other side was nothing like Okhema, or anything Phainon had seen before. It was a hellish, desolate place. A vast, endless void stretched out in all directions, filled with wailing souls trapped in eternal torment. Their cries echoed through the expanse, and the ground was littered with debris—broken, twisted remnants of lives long past. The air was thick, oppressive, suffocating, a stark contrast to the purity of Okhema.

Phainon's body reacted before his mind could catch up. The hunger, the sharp, insatiable thirst, took over in an instant. He pulled away from Mydei, his senses zeroing in on the lost souls around them. His eyes glowed faintly, a wicked smile curling on his lips.

Without a word, he lunged, tearing into the closest soul with all the ferocity of a predator. Blood—dark, black, and thick—spilled around him as he tore and devoured. The air around him seemed to hum, the power of the souls feeding him, invigorating him. Phainon reveled in the release, the freedom to feast without restraint, without concern for the consequences.

Mydei stood back, his gaze lingering on Phainon's frenzied movements. The prince's face remained impassive, though the faintest hint of sorrow seemed to linger in his eyes. He had brought Phainon here for centuries, and though he knew the cost, it didn't matter. Not anymore.

Phainon was in his element now, a true demon—a force of nature unleashed. Mydei, as always, looked away, refusing to watch what Phainon became during these moments.

The corruption of Phainon didn't concern him—not really. He couldn't afford to care. Not when this was the only way to ease the pain of purification. Phainon had to suffer, and if that meant being dragged into this hellish place after every ritual, then so be it. Mydei had long since resigned himself to it.

The prince stood in silence as Phainon tore into the souls, the blood staining the ground, the sounds of his feeding echoing in the endless void. Every cry, every plea for mercy, was drowned out by the frantic energy of the Incubi's hunger.

When the feeding finally stopped, Phainon was left panting, exhausted, covered in the remains of those he had devoured. His body trembled, but the hunger was gone for now.

Mydei moved to his side, offering a hand to help him up, his face unreadable.

“Ready to go back?” Mydei asked, his voice low.

Phainon nodded weakly, his breath still coming in ragged gasps, his eyes glazed and distant. “Yeah… just… give me a minute.”

Without another word, Mydei led Phainon back through the passage, away from the souls, back to their own world. The air felt different now, less oppressive, but still heavy with the weight of everything they had just endured.

It had become their routine, an unspoken agreement: purification for Mydei, suffering for Phainon, and feeding in a place where the corruption could stretch its tendrils even further in both of them, even Mydei to keep the other living. It was a cycle they had lived with for centuries.

And Mydei, despite the weight of it all, would carry it for as long as he had to.

After Phainon was cleaned up and dressed in loose, comfortable clothes, Mydei led him back to his chambers. The exhaustion from the ritual weighed heavily on the Incubi, his steps slow and unsteady as Mydei supported him. Once inside the chambers, Mydei helped him to the bed and settled him under the covers. Phainon’s breathing was shallow but steady now, his body sinking into the softness of the sheets as his mind slowly relaxed.

Mydei slipped into the bed beside him, pulling the covers up over them both. He let out a long, almost imperceptible sigh as he closed his eyes, trying to unwind after the endless routine. It was a quiet, still moment—one that felt too rare to be fully enjoyed. His mind replayed the purification and

its lingering effects, the guilt gnawing at him. But for now, he pushed it aside, letting the warmth of Phainon's body next to him be a small comfort in the chaos they both lived in.

Phainon, though exhausted, shifted slightly in his sleep, his face nuzzling into Mydei's neck. The warmth of his breath against Mydei's skin was soothing, though a little too intimate. For a moment, Mydei thought it might be the aftermath of the feeding—how touch-starved Phainon was after enduring the pain of the ritual.

Then, unexpectedly, he felt something else. A pressure against his neck, followed by a sharp, sudden sensation as Phainon bit into it.

Mydei's body tensed immediately, his breath hitching in his throat as he froze. He hadn't expected this, not in the quiet aftermath of everything they had just been through. The bite was sharp and intentional, Phainon's teeth sinking into his skin in a way that sent a shiver down Mydei's spine.

Before Mydei could react, Phainon moved with surprising strength, rolling on top of him. Mydei was momentarily stunned by the shift, the sudden weight of the Incubi pinning him to the bed. He opened his mouth to speak, to ask what was happening, but the words died in his throat as Phainon whispered against his ear.

"I'll do anything you want after this, Dei… just let me indulge a little longer."

The warmth of Phainon's breath against his ear sent another shiver through Mydei, and before he could think, Phainon's lips were on his neck again. The Incubi's hands roamed, his touch growing more possessive, teasing as it moved lower and lower down Mydei's body. He could feel the hunger in the other's actions, the desperate need that had been kept in check for far too long.

Mydei's heart raced. The situation felt foreign, uncharted, and for a moment, he had no idea how to navigate it. His breath came out in soft gasps as Phainon's mouth worked its way down to his collarbone, sucking,

nibbling. Mydei shifted, his body instinctively trying to pull away—but Phainon's hands were firm, his grip unyielding.

"Phainon…" Mydei managed to say, his voice low, but his tone betraying a hint of nervousness. "Stop…" He hadn't meant for the command to come out as a breathless whisper, but it did, laced with a tinge of something he couldn't quite place.

Phainon paused, his lips still lingering at Mydei's neck, his breath hot against his skin. His eyes, though heavy with exhaustion, glinted with a dark, knowing hunger that set Mydei's pulse racing.

"I'm sorry, Mydei," Phainon whispered softly, but his tone was anything but apologetic. It was more like a plea, the softness of the words contradicting the intensity of the actions. He looked at Mydei then, searching his eyes for some kind of permission, or perhaps an understanding.

But Mydei didn't want this, not right now. Not after everything that had just happened. He reached up, gently cupping Phainon's jaw, and with surprising gentleness, he guided the Incubi's head away from his neck.

Phainon let out a soft sigh of frustration, but he didn't push further. Instead, he settled back against Mydei's chest, curling into him with a quiet, exhausted murmur. Within moments, the tension in his body relaxed, his breath evening out as he fell into a deep, untroubled sleep.

Mydei, on the other hand, stayed awake long after, his thoughts swirling as he stared at the ceiling, the weight of everything pressing down on him again. He couldn't help but wonder where the line was, where the end of this routine would lead them. How far would they go before everything they had became too much to bear?

But for now, all he could do was lie there, feeling Phainon's weight against him, the heat of his body a constant reminder of their bond—one that seemed to grow more complicated by the day.

The morning in the Celestial Realm was never truly morning—it was light eternal, shifting in hues but never fading. Dawn unfolded in gilded tones, brushing across the high spires and endless stretches of sky. It was a world sculpted from divinity, a kingdom untouched by mortal frailty.

And yet, within the sanctum of Mydei's chambers, the scene was far less grand.

Phainon sprawled across the bed, limbs draped over silk sheets, lazily stretching as if he had all the time in the world. He had regained his strength—no, he had more than regained it. Mydei's blood worked wonders, mending him from the inside out, and now he was back to his usual self, eyes gleaming with something both knowing and mischievous.

Meanwhile, Mydei stood near the arched windows, already dressed, his presence composed as ever. The faint shimmer of his divinity pulsed with the celestial air, an unspoken authority laced into his very existence. Even in stillness, he was something untouchable.

Phainon, however, didn't seem impressed.

"Must you always be so diligent first thing in the morning?" he drawled, voice thick with sleep but carrying its usual teasing lilt. "You make the rest of us look bad."

Mydei didn't glance his way. "You do that well enough on your own."

Phainon smirked, rolling onto his side, propping his head up with one hand. "Harsh. What's the occasion? Another grand celestial decree? Smite some sinners? Or is it just another day of being *His Radiance, Crown Prince of the Heavens?*"

Mydei turned then, slow and deliberate. "Get up."

Phainon hummed, tilting his head. "That wasn't an answer."

"I wasn't offering one."

Phainon sighed theatrically, shifting but making no real move to rise. “Give me a reason.”

Mydei stepped forward, and for a moment, something heavier settled between them—an unspoken expectation, a reminder of who Mydei was outside these chambers. Outside their moments of familiarity.

Then, just as easily, the tension shattered.

“You’ve had more than enough time to lounge,” Mydei said flatly. “Unless you’d like to go another round in purification.”

Phainon was up before the words had fully left Mydei’s lips.

“Well, when you put it like that,” he muttered, stretching once more, a slow, languid motion before he straightened. His smirk returned, effortless. “Fine, fine. Lead the way, *Your Radiance*.”

Mydei gave him a look.

Phainon grinned, unfazed. Some things never changed.

Chapter 2: Unspoken Temptations

Chapter Summary

> Phainon and Mydei: handling celestial disputes, testing boundaries, and navigating an unspoken tension—all in a day's work.

Chapter Notes

> Again shorter than usual, but I legit forgot the plot I had going on with this cause I didn't write the outline so I just blazed through it.
>
> I've pretty much given up on trying to remember so it's just gonna be really self-indulgent and whatever comes in my head first I'll write, fingers crossed you guys will like it
>
> (For some reason I also can't back read without getting embarrassed so there is also that😭)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The assembly chamber stood in silence.

It was a place of celestial law—vast, towering, woven from light and stone older than mortal understanding. The air itself was thick with judgment, settling over the gathered deities like an unseen hand pressing them into place. The ones before Mydei were not mortals, nor were they weak. And yet, before him, they hesitated.

He did not raise his voice. He never needed to.

The warring deities had called for arbitration, their dispute dragging on for decades. Even here, even now, their pride kept them bristling, shoulders squared, eyes darting toward him as if daring him to choose a side. But Mydei remained still, gaze sweeping across them, letting their grievances crumble under his silence.

“You forget yourselves.”

The words were quiet, but they cut through the chamber like a blade.

A ripple of something unspoken passed through the gathered gods. Even the most indignant among them stilled.

There was no anger in Mydei’s expression, no outward show of force, only the simple, undeniable truth—*there was no argument here that could stand against him.*

Phainon watched from the marble steps, lounging against a pillar.

It was almost cruel in a way, how easily Mydei unraveled them. Not through fury, not through threats—just sheer certainty.

One of the deities dared to speak. “You cannot expect us to—”

Mydei turned his head.

The deity fell silent mid-sentence, their throat working around a sound that never quite escaped. They looked away.

Phainon exhaled a quiet laugh, tilting his head, watching Mydei as one might admire a rare spectacle. It wasn’t just power—it was the complete absence of doubt. No hesitation, no missteps. It was intoxicating in its own way.

And yet…

Phainon’s gaze flicked toward the gathered celestials, where something far less composed stirred beneath their polished exteriors.

Their reverence was real, but beneath it, there was unease.

And where there was unease, there was want.

He felt it coil beneath the surface, deep-seated and carefully buried—repressed desire, urges they would never dare acknowledge, let alone act

on. It took no effort at all to feel the shift in the chamber as he let his presence unfurl, subtle at first, then pressing, sinking under their skin.

He could taste it.

A celestial attendant's breath hitched, their fingers flexing against the folds of their robes. Another deity's pulse stuttered, gaze flicking to him before snapping away too quickly, as if looking for too long was dangerous.

Oh, *they knew.*

Knew what he was, knew what he could offer, knew exactly how easily he could coax out the things they tried so desperately to bury.

Phainon let his stance loosen, a slow, languid stretch, letting his smirk sharpen just enough. He didn't even need to speak.

And that made it worse.

A god across the chamber swallowed hard, the movement barely perceptible, but Phainon *felt* it, felt their barely-contained revulsion twisting with something else—something they'd never admit.

They hated him. Feared him.

But none of them could ignore him.

And Mydei?

He let it happen.

He did nothing to dismiss him, said nothing to break the moment. As if daring them to object.

No one did.

With the dispute settled—at least for now—Mydei remained, speaking with those who required his judgment, finalizing what needed to be done. His

voice was calm, decisive, and unwavering, and though Phainon had long since grown used to it, the effect on others was something else entirely.

He strolled away from the main gathering, his fingers skimming over gilded balustrades, the cool touch of celestial metal humming faintly beneath his skin. Mydei's presence still filled the chamber, commanding, absolute—and Phainon *felt* the responses it drew.

It wasn't just reverence.

He caught it in stolen glances, in barely contained breaths, in the way certain deities held themselves just a little too still, as if suppressing something improper. He didn't even need to try to sense it—desire, deeply buried, gnawed at the edges of their restraint.

It was amusing, in a way. Even in a place where virtue reigned supreme, no one was immune.

Not even him.

Phainon exhaled slowly, rolling his shoulders in an attempt to shake off the tension curling along his spine. He felt this way too often these days. Mydei's presence had always had an effect—he'd known that for centuries—but lately, it was getting harder to ignore.

Suppressing a groan, he dragged a hand through his hair and kept walking.

That was when he noticed her.

A woman stood at the periphery of the chamber, wreathed in cool blue light. She wasn't some lesser celestial, no minor goddess or nameless attendant. No, she was something old.

And her soul smelled delicious.

Phainon's smirk curled, slow and deliberate, as he made his way toward her.

"You're new," he murmured, voice dipping into something smooth and knowing. He let his gaze trail over her, taking his time. "Or at least, new

here."

She glanced at him, unimpressed at first—until recognition flickered behind her gaze.

"Ah," she said, tilting her head. "The incubus."

Phainon grinned. "Caught on quick, have you?"

Her lips curved slightly, something unreadable in her expression. "You reek of indulgence."

"And you," Phainon murmured, stepping just a little closer, "reek of restraint."

Her eyes darkened.

Oh, this would be *fun*.

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The last of the celestial squabbles had been settled—at least for now. The echoes of whispered arguments, the tension that had filled the air, all dissipated under Mydei's unwavering resolve. He stood still for a moment, his mind clearing, the weight of his duties pressing down upon him for only the briefest of moments. He exhaled, the faintest hint of irritation tugging at his thoughts.

This was never how he wanted to spend his time. Celestial disputes, petty squabbles over dominions and power—he'd heard them all before, and honestly, the entire charade wore on him more than he cared to admit. But, as Crown Prince, he had a role to fulfill, and it was one he could not escape.

Still, a part of him longed for the quiet, the simplicity of solitude. Something that, oddly, had become increasingly harder to find.

His gaze swept across the chamber, searching for the presence he had come to expect. Phainon.

He wasn’t there.

A brief flicker of something twisted in his chest. A moment of unease that he quickly buried.

Two possibilities crossed his mind—one, Phainon had simply decided to leave. Wander off and amuse himself, as was his nature. But the second…

Mydei exhaled, refusing to let that thought solidify. The second option was something he didn’t want to think about, something that lingered too close to discomfort.

So, he let it go, and forced himself to focus on the more pressing matters. He would deal with Phainon later. Or perhaps, he wouldn’t—he wasn’t sure which was more appealing at the moment.

Regardless, the room now felt empty without him. And for a fleeting moment, Mydei found himself longing for the presence he’d rather ignore.

The long hall was dim, lit only by faint, glowing lanterns that swayed with the passing wind, their flickering light casting shifting shadows across the marble floor. The soft, rhythmic hum of music filled the air, the performers skillfully moving through their routine, but Mydei wasn’t paying attention. He rarely did when he was forced to sit through these rituals, these grand performances meant to entertain the high-ranking beings in the realm. He was here out of obligation, his presence a formality, but the event wasn’t engaging enough to distract him from the weight of his thoughts.

He leaned back, legs spread wide across the high-backed chair, his posture as comfortable as it was commanding. His robes settled over his thighs, the fabric loose and relaxed, allowing him to sit how he wanted without concern for appearances. His gaze remained distant, staring at the performers with no real interest as his mind wandered, reflecting on things both mundane and important.

Suddenly, the atmosphere shifted.

A presence moved behind him, warm and familiar, and Mydei knew before the whispered voice reached his ear that it was Phainon.

“Mydei,” Phainon’s voice was low, dripping with playful amusement, as he leaned in close. “You miss me?”

The familiar weight of the incubi’s breath sent a brief shiver down Mydei’s spine, though he refused to let it show. He didn’t respond immediately, unwilling to engage with the teasing tone, but Phainon wasn’t one to take silence as rejection.

Before Mydei could turn around, Phainon was already making himself at home—on Mydei’s lap. His body settled with an ease that suggested he had done this a thousand times before, his legs draping lazily over Mydei’s, his head resting comfortably against his chest.

The scene didn’t raise any eyebrows. It never did anymore. Those in the room—beings of great status and stature—had long since learned that Mydei’s familiarity with the incubi wasn’t something to be questioned. Not that any of them dared to.

Phainon let out a soft hum of satisfaction as he adjusted himself, comfortable in the space. His fingers trailed lazily over Mydei’s thigh, sending a ripple of warmth through the prince’s body. Mydei, still half-absorbed in the quiet performance in front of him, didn’t immediately move. There was no need. It was easier this way.

“Must you always be this… relaxed?” Mydei finally said, his voice laced with a quiet edge, though it didn’t carry the sharpness it once had.

Phainon smiled up at him, a playful glint in his eyes. “What can I say? I’m comfortable.” His hands wandered down a little further, fingers teasingly brushing the hem of Mydei’s robes.

For a moment, there was a strange stillness. The noise of the performance seemed far away, muted by the intensity of Phainon’s presence. Mydei’s gaze faltered just briefly, before he straightened his posture, ignoring the subtle pulse of warmth that began to bloom in his chest. His hands, which

had rested loosely at his sides, now adjusted their grip, fingers curled slightly into the fabric of his seat.

It was in that moment that a memory flickered to life, unbidden, from a time long past.

It hadn’t been nearly as easy the first time.

Mydei had been sitting in this very hall, though it had been a different performance then—a gathering full of deities, powerfully adorned and full of self-importance. He had been younger then, more rigid, still trying to navigate the expectations that came with being crowned Prince of the Heavens. The weight of the throne was ever-present, even when he didn’t wear the crown.

Phainon had appeared as he often did, effortlessly entering the space with the quiet chaos that only he seemed capable of causing. The same teasing smirk on his face, the same dangerous allure in his movements, but this time, there was something new in his eyes. A challenge.

Before Mydei could protest, Phainon had dropped down without warning—without any ceremony—right into his lap, draping himself across him like an unruly cat.

“What the hell do you think you’re doing?” Mydei had asked, his voice tight, his face flushed with the suddenness of it. His hands had shot out instinctively to push the incubi away, but Phainon had only laughed, unbothered.

The room had gone silent. There had been whispers, muttered insults from those who thought they could see through this brazen act. “He’s corrupting the Crown Prince,” one had said, their voice thick with disapproval. “A creature like him—this is what comes from consorting with demons.”

Mydei hadn’t noticed the muttering at first. He had been too busy trying to figure out how to get Phainon off his lap, how to contain the unexpected

sensation blooming in his chest. But then the whispers had become louder, more direct. Eyes had turned to him, full of judgment and fear.

He had grown tense, trying to pull away from Phainon, to make some kind of show of it—but Phainon had merely laughed, leaning in closer, his lips brushing Mydei's ear.

"They don't know anything about us," Phainon had whispered, his voice low and dangerous. "But you do."

That had been the beginning.

Phainon had stayed. And no matter how hard Mydei had tried to pretend it didn't affect him, something had shifted. And now, here they were.

Back in the present, the room had grown a little warmer, the flickering of lanterns dancing across Mydei's skin as Phainon shifted on his lap, his body a weight of comfort—something all too familiar. The performance continued around them, but Mydei couldn't ignore the slight pressure of Phainon's hands on his legs, his subtle but insistent touch as it moved along his thigh.

"You've got no shame," Mydei murmured, though there was no anger behind the words now. Just a tired resignation.

"I know," Phainon said, his lips curving into that same damnable smirk. "But you don't mind."

Mydei didn't reply, his body betraying him as he let himself settle back, accepting the warmth and the strange comfort that only Phainon could bring.

It was a game. A dangerous, messy game. But it was their game, and Mydei found that, much to his surprise, he didn't mind it as much as he used to.

The performance continued to unfold before them, but Mydei's attention drifted with every subtle shift of Phainon's body against his. The dancers on

the stage moved in harmony, but all he could focus on was the heat between his legs, the slow, deliberate pressure that Phainon's body exerted against him. It was an unspoken game—Phainon testing him, pushing boundaries, daring him to feel more, to want more.

At first, it was innocent, or at least Mydei tried to convince himself it was. A languid stretch of Phainon's hand across his lap, a brush of fingertips over his thigh, which, despite the mildness, sent a jolt of warmth through him. Mydei barely moved, attempting to ignore the gnawing sensation building in his chest, but Phainon's subtle presence was relentless. His body shifted ever closer, the space between them shrinking with each breath, until Mydei could feel his heartbeat pulsing in time with the slow, lazy drag of Phainon's hand inching dangerously close to places Mydei wasn't ready to acknowledge.

"Stop," Mydei whispered, though the word barely left his lips. It was more an instinct than a command. He couldn't let himself react too loudly, not in front of everyone. Not when the eyes around them were too busy with the ritual to even notice. But Phainon knew better. He felt every beat of Mydei's heart, the hesitation that slipped from his tone, and most of all, the tightening in his muscles that gave away more than Mydei would ever admit.

Phainon's fingers didn't stop. They didn't even falter. They moved lower, sliding across Mydei's skin with an almost unbearable slowness, barely perceptible at first. But that was all Phainon needed—just enough of a touch to keep Mydei's pulse erratic, his breath shaky. His head tilted just enough that his lips brushed the delicate curve of Mydei's neck, not soft, but insistent. "You want me to stop?" Phainon's voice was a low hum, just barely audible, and Mydei's insides twisted at the sound of it.

Another weak attempt to push him away. "Phainon, stop," Mydei repeated, but it lacked the force of someone in control. His voice quivered slightly, but the lingering sensation of Phainon's hand moving lower, the heat of his breath against his ear, made it impossible to fully compose himself.

For a moment, Mydei thought Phainon might pull away, but instead, Phainon pressed closer. His hand continued to trace the line of Mydei's

waist, the path so slow, so calculated, and so excruciatingly close to the edge that Mydei could feel the last shreds of his composure shattering. Phainon's head shifted, moving lower, his lips brushing Mydei's collarbone as though testing for a reaction.

Mydei's pulse quickened. He couldn't tell if it was from anger or something else. His breath grew shallow, his chest tight, the burning sensation in his core so vivid he almost couldn't bear it. But he still fought, still tried to maintain control, even though it was slipping further with every caress.

He opened his mouth to speak again, to push Phainon away properly this time, but the words caught in his throat. Instead, a soft, almost imperceptible moan escaped, a response he couldn't suppress. It wasn't the protest Phainon had expected. It was something more vulnerable. Something more like *need*.

Phainon heard it, and it made his smirk grow wider, though he did nothing more than lean into the touch, allowing the moment to linger longer than Mydei could handle. His hand reached lower still, brushing over the waistband of Mydei's trousers. Every muscle in Mydei's body tensed, and for just a heartbeat, he thought he might explode from the sheer tension. His breath was ragged, and for a moment, he thought he might lose himself to the heat of Phainon's touch.

And then, just as suddenly as it began, Phainon stopped.

Mydei's breath hitched, the sudden halt leaving him strangely empty, like something had been ripped away before he could come to terms with it. Phainon's hand stilled, and for a long, pregnant moment, neither of them spoke.

Phainon, his face buried in the crook of Mydei's neck, let out a soft sigh, something between regret and something darker—something more selfish. "I… went too far," he murmured, though there was no apology in his tone. It was a statement. A fact. He was still so close that Mydei could feel the warmth of his body, the heat radiating from him. And though Phainon had stopped, the tension in the air thickened instead of dissipating.

Mydei’s heart was still racing, and it wasn’t just from the discomfort of being so exposed. There was a lingering sensation of hunger that he couldn’t shake, a heat that clung to his skin and curled under his ribs. Despite himself, he found himself wanting more—his body betraying him.

He swallowed hard, finally breaking the silence. “Don’t… don’t do that again,” Mydei said, though his voice was almost strained, like he wasn’t sure he meant it. His words should have sounded firm, but instead they came out shaky, barely able to mask the burning desire that hadn’t gone away.

Phainon didn’t respond at first. Instead, he pressed his face further into Mydei’s neck, his lips brushing lightly against the skin. “I won’t,” he said quietly, though the edge in his voice made it clear he didn’t truly mean it. Not in the way Mydei would have liked.

The air between them was electric, filled with a tension so thick it was suffocating. Mydei’s thoughts were tangled, and even though Phainon had pulled away physically, it was impossible to shake the grip he still had on him—on his body, on his emotions, on everything.

It was maddening.

He indulged it anyway.

Chapter End Notes

> You know what, I’m being so srs rn, comment any, and I mean ANY ideas you have for this and there is a 99% chance I’m adding that in the next chapter. ANYTHING.
>
> (So uh, who tops)

Chapter 3: Through the Veil

Chapter Summary

> Phainon gets lost in a book while Mydei patiently waits, then drags him out with a promise to bring him next time.
>
> Later, Phainon uses his totally legit charm and a stolen relic to sneak into a citadel, proving that boredom is the real danger here.

Chapter Notes

> Sorry to anyone waiting for new aus, I'm working on it but it's bothering me how I still haven't finished this😭 (Actively multitasking by writing a Villian au with After hours chapter 2 tho!!)
>
> Voting last chapter I legit tried counting but I'm not very bright so I kept getting different results (excuse my dumbass❤) so I'm just gonna delay the sex scene for later uhdjdjdjd

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The moon loomed high, swollen with silver light, casting its glow over the endless stretch of the heavens. Phainon stood at the edge of an otherworldly precipice, the ground beneath him smooth as polished bone, dissolving into mist where it met the void. A place untouched, unmarred, where the unworthy could not tread.

Below, the Sanctum of Aetherion shimmered—a temple carved from veined gold and lapis, its spires piercing the fabric of the cosmos itself. It hovered in stillness, defying gravity, a place where only the highest of celestial beings were permitted entry. A sacred ground. A realm of gods.

And Phainon could go no further.

His eyes remained locked on the distant structure, expression unreadable. He did not pace, did not shift—he simply waited. His usual languid ease

was absent, tension coiled beneath his skin like a beast restrained.

The hunger clawed at him.

Not for the temple itself—he had no interest in begging for a seat at a table that would never welcome him. The heavens had long tolerated his existence, nothing more. That was a battle he'd stopped fighting ages ago.

But Mydei was in there.

And that was the real test.

The celestial alignment had begun a month ago. A rare event, one that came only once every few centuries, when the stars shifted in their grand design and the very air became thick with purity.

Aetheris, the Month of Ascension.

For gods, it was a time of renewal. For incubi, it was a curse.

Phainon had gone thirty days without feeding. No indulgence, no stolen pleasure, nothing to sate the gnawing void in his chest. He told himself it was a game—a test of his own willpower, a way to amuse himself.

But that was a lie.

It was never just a game. He was proving something.

That he could endure. That he could be more than his nature. That he could stand at Mydei's side as an equal, not a creature bound by base instincts.

Yet even now, his restraint was slipping.

He could feel Mydei's presence, a storm of power radiating from within those gilded halls, amplified a thousandfold by the rites taking place inside. It wasn't just strength—it was a pull, something ancient and unrelenting, something Phainon felt in the marrow of his being.

His fingers curled into fists.

The sheer force of Mydei's energy, heightened by the rites of Aetheris, was overwhelming. Phainon could taste it in the air, the weight of it pressing against his skin like an unspoken challenge. It was unbearable.

His body screamed at him to take, to consume, to devour.

He exhaled sharply, forcing his muscles to loosen, shoving the hunger back down where it belonged.

Not yet. Not like this.

He would not crawl. He would not beg.

He would endure.

If he could make it through this night—just one more night—he would have proven himself.

And when Mydei finally emerged from that sanctum, glowing with the aftermath of whatever holy rites had transpired inside, Phainon would meet him with a smirk, as if none of this had touched him at all.

Even if it destroyed him.

Phainon remained where he was, perched at the cliff's edge like a creature of ruin staring into a world that did not want him. The temple's golden gates finally parted, a soft, resonant hum filling the space as figures emerged, bathed in the ethereal light of Aetheris.

And there he was.

Mydei stepped into the open air, his presence a force unto itself. The celestial rites still clung to him, settling into his skin like stardust, woven into the folds of his robes. His posture was straight, every movement controlled, effortless. The sheer weight of his divinity was staggering.

But it wasn't just his power.

It was the sharp cut of his jaw, the unwavering set of his gaze, the way his presence commanded the space around him without a word. He looked untouchable. Unshaken. Regal.

Phainon's lips curled slightly, lazy amusement flickering in his gaze. It was always a sight to behold—this Mydei.

Yet his attention soon drifted to the figure walking beside him.

A Damion.

That was the closest approximation to what they were called, though there was no true translation in human tongues. A being forged from light, neither mortal nor god, bound to the will of the heavens. They were guardians, messengers, watchers—a class of celestial beings just beneath the gods themselves.

And this one walked beside Mydei as if they were equals.

Phainon tilted his head slightly, watching them converse. The Damion's tone was respectful, but something in the cadence of their voice was just a fraction too careful, too measured.

They did not look at Mydei as one looks at a prince, but rather as one looks at something sacred, something untouchable.

Phainon had seen that kind of reverence before. It was a reverence that demanded distance.

He remained where he was, an idle observer, fingers tapping against his knee in slow, rhythmic beats. He didn't move, didn't speak—he simply watched.

And then, the Damion's gaze flickered toward him.

They did not react outright. There was no sneer, no open disdain. Their face remained impassive, expression crafted with careful neutrality, but something in their bearing shifted, almost imperceptibly. A stiffness in the shoulders. A quiet tension.

Like a blade being restrained from being drawn.

They did not speak to him. They wouldn’t dare.

Not because of what he was. Because of who he belonged to.

Phainon hummed under his breath, eyes half-lidded, feigning disinterest even as the moment stretched. This was nothing new.

Tolerated. Never accepted.

The amusement should have been bitter.

Instead, it vanished entirely the moment Mydei’s gaze landed on him.

Without hesitation, without a second thought, the Crown Prince turned away from the Damion and strode toward him. The dismissal was not cruel, not unkind—but it was final.

And Phainon, despite himself, felt his lips twitch upward.

Just slightly.

Not enough to be a smirk, not enough to betray anything—but enough to take note of the near-imperceptible shift in Damion’s expression.

There was no anger. No disrespect. Only the slightest tightening of their jaw, the briefest flicker in their expression before it was smoothed away.

Because for all their divine status, for all the ceremony and reverence that surrounded them—

They had just been dismissed in favor of an incubi.

And they could do nothing about it.

Phainon didn’t bother standing. He remained seated at the cliff’s edge, head tilted just slightly, watching Mydei approach with that ever-present languid ease. The prince looked as composed as ever, but Phainon didn’t miss the

way his gaze flickered—subtle, assessing, like he was already preparing for whatever nonsense the incubi was about to pull.

“You know,” Phainon drawled, stretching his arms behind his head, “I almost thought you wouldn’t notice me.”

Mydei stopped a few paces away, giving him a look that was somewhere between exasperation and amusement. “I always notice you. That’s the problem.”

Phainon grinned. “Flattering.”

“It wasn’t meant to be.”

Mydei turned slightly, already moving past him as if to leave this exchange at that, but Phainon, of course, had other plans.

With a deliberate motion, he unfurled his tail.

It wasn’t often that he used it so openly. The sleek, dark appendage—normally coiled around his waist or kept out of sight—moved with ease, curving through the air before wrapping gently around Mydei’s forearm.

And then, without a word, Phainon pulled.

It wasn’t rough, wasn’t forceful—just a slow, insistent tug meant to guide rather than drag. A silent, move it along.

Mydei let out a short, irritated-sounding exhale, but he didn’t resist. Didn’t even try.

He just grumbled under his breath and kept walking.

Phainon’s tail remained looped around him, a loose tether.

From the corner of his eye, Phainon caught the movement.

Damion took a step forward. A small one. Barely noticeable, but there. Their posture shifted, their weight subtly redistributed—a telltale sign of

someone suppressing the instinct to intervene.

Because to them, this was irreverence. This was audacity.

An incubi, touching the Crown Prince so casually? Handling him as if they were equals? Unthinkable.

But before Damion could act—before they could so much as open their mouth—Mydei shot them a glance.

Not sharp. Not reprimanding. Just a look.

A simple, wordless confirmation that he had no issue with this. That there was no need for intervention.

That he didn’t care.

And Damion, despite their station, despite everything, had no choice but to accept that.

Phainon felt the corner of his mouth twitch upward once again.

Oh, he had noticed that.

Phainon let himself fall into step beside him, gaze drifting idly as they moved. The Damion was gone now, but their presence lingered, like a song cut off before the final note.

Phainon’s tail loosened slightly from Mydei’s arm but didn’t retreat entirely, the tip flicking lazily against the fabric of his sleeve. It wasn’t intentional. Or maybe it was. He wasn’t in the mood to think too deeply about it.

They walked in silence for a while, the path before them smooth and untouched. Then, without warning, Mydei veered. A shift so subtle that most wouldn’t have caught it, but Phainon wasn’t most. His steps faltered for half a second before he adjusted, his tail curling instinctively tighter as if to reel Mydei back in.

Instead, he let himself be guided.

Still, his hand lifted, fingers catching Mydei's wrist—not to stop him, not even to question. Just to feel the pulse beneath his skin, the warmth.

"Mm?" Phainon's hum was low, inquisitive. Not pressing, not demanding. Just a soft sound of acknowledgment.

Mydei didn't answer immediately. His face remained impassive, unreadable, but for a single breath, something shifted. It wasn't much—just a flicker, an unreadable something behind his eyes—but Phainon caught it.

And then, just as quickly, it was gone.

Phainon tilted his head slightly, but the smile he conjured was effortless. "Going somewhere?"

Mydei's gaze flicked to him, unreadable still. "Does it matter?"

Phainon let out a quiet chuckle, releasing his wrist as he stepped closer, their arms brushing. "Not at all."

His tail uncurled fully this time, slipping away. But still, it hovered, close enough that the warmth remained.

They continued forward, side by side, and Phainon told himself it meant nothing.

But he had seen that flicker.

And he wanted to know what it meant.

As they walked, the air between them was quiet—not heavy, not tense. Just quiet. A rare sort of stillness that Phainon wasn't entirely used to, but didn't mind.

Then, soft and low, Mydei began to hum.

It was simple, unembellished—not meant for an audience, not meant for anyone at all. Just something effortless, something that settled into the space between them without needing to be acknowledged.

And Phainon, without thinking, listened.

His gaze stayed forward, but his steps synced unconsciously with the rhythm. He didn’t recognize the melody, didn’t know if it was something old or something Mydei had merely strung together absentmindedly.

It didn’t matter.

What did matter was the sudden, firm grasp around his wrist.

Phainon blinked as Mydei’s fingers wrapped around him—not harsh, not hurried, but with a certainty that didn’t allow for argument. Then, without a word, Mydei changed direction again, dragging him along.

Phainon let himself be led, more curious than anything. He could have resisted if he wanted to, but he didn’t. Instead, he followed, steps loose and easy as Mydei pulled him toward what looked like… nothing.

Just empty space.

Blank, untouched, unremarkable. Nothingness stretched out before them, seamless and endless, and yet Mydei didn’t pause. Didn’t hesitate.

Phainon arched a brow, lips curving slightly. “Fascinating,” he mused. “You’ve brought me to absolutely nowhere.”

Mydei didn’t respond, too focused on… something.

He shifted slightly, adjusting his stance, gaze sharp as if aligning himself with an unseen mark. Then, with a final movement—one that felt deliberate, purposeful—he stepped forward.

And the nothingness peeled away.

Like a veil being lifted, reality seemed to bend, unfold, reshape. Structures materialized where there had been none, shelves stretching high and endless, gilded spines catching the light of unseen flames. The scent of parchment and ink drifted through the air, mingling with something older, something deeper—the weight of knowledge itself.

A library.

Phainon let out a low breath, his amusement shifting into something genuine, intrigued.

Mydei finally released him, gesturing toward the expanse before them. “Welcome,” he said smoothly, “to my library.”

Phainon took a slow step forward, gaze flickering over the towering shelves, the countless tomes. Then, lazily, he turned to Mydei, expression unreadable.

“You can read?”

Mydei blinked once, slow.

Then, ever so slightly, his brows knit together, an almost imperceptible shift—like he wasn’t sure whether to be offended or amused.

“…Brat,” he muttered, exhaling through his nose.

Then, without another word, he turned his back on Phainon and strode forward, stepping deeper into the library. His presence fit the space too well—like he belonged here, like this place had been shaped around him rather than the other way around.

“Read. Don’t read,” Mydei said idly over his shoulder. “Just don’t touch anything you shouldn’t.”

Phainon grinned, watching him go, sharp and entertained. Now that was interesting.

Phainon stretched languidly, arms arching over his head, tail flicking in idle amusement as he leaned just a little too far back—

A soft thud sounded as his hand barely grazed the edge of a precariously stacked tome.

Mydei, without even turning around, let out a warning sigh.

Phainon huffed a quiet laugh but straightened, lazily scanning the shelves. The library was vast, lined with books of every size, their spines worn with age or pristine in their bindings. He wasn't much for reading—not like Mydei, who had that unfairly sharp mind and the patience for all this.

But then—something caught his eye.

A book, tucked neatly among the rest, its title etched in a script that wasn't just old. It was ancient.

Phainon's fingers paused above the spine. His eyes narrowed slightly.

Kremnoan.

A language almost forgotten, its words older than empires, forged in a place that most considered half myth, half grave.

Castrum Kremnos.

Phainon knew of it—not just from records, but from Mydei himself. From the rare, fleeting moments when the prince let something slip.

Like when Phainon had grinned at him, sharp and teasing, and drawled, *What, are you scared?*

And Mydei, without missing a beat, had said, *Kremnos has no word for fear.*

Or when Phainon, ever the instigator, had pushed further teasing, *No word for giving up, either? Or surrender? Or regret*?

And Mydei, ever the same, had simply replied, *No.*

Phainon had laughed, shaking his head. *I'm starting to wonder if your language has any words at all.*

And Mydei had only looked at him, silent, unreadable.

Phainon ran a finger along the spine of the book.

Well. Time to find out.

With a quiet hum, he pulled it from the shelf.

Phainon had lost track of time.

He had settled into a quiet corner of the library, a space that felt untouched, almost forgotten. The chair beneath him was far too comfortable, and the book in his hands, though heavy, sat easily in his grasp.

At first, he had only skimmed, expecting dense, rigid text. But the deeper he read, the more the words pulled him in.

The language was old, unfamiliar—its rhythm unlike anything he knew. And yet, something about it felt close. Like hearing the echo of a song he didn't remember learning.

His gaze flickered up for just a moment. Across the room, Mydei sat deep in thought, completely still, as if the rest of the world had never touched him. He always looked that way—untouched, unmoved, set apart in a way that seemed almost effortless.

Phainon's fingers drifted over the page before he turned it.

Then, he stopped.

A single word stood out.

EKTHA.

His brow furrowed slightly. Without thinking, he ran his fingers over the ink, tracing the letters in silence.

Unchanging oath. A bond that cannot be severed.

The meaning lingered in his thoughts, settling into a space he hadn't realized was open.

A bond that couldn't be severed.

Phainon exhaled slowly, tilting his head back. It was an odd thing, for a language to have such certainty in a single word. To define something so absolute, without hesitation.

A promise that didn’t break. A tie that didn’t fray.

He let the thought drift for a while, rolling it over in his mind. Then, with a quiet chuckle—more amused than anything—he shook his head and turned the page.

The sound of a book snapping shut broke the silence.

“We should go.”

Phainon blinked, dragging himself back to the present.

Mydei stood beside him, as calm as ever, though his gaze flickered—just briefly—to the book in Phainon’s hands.

Without waiting for an answer, he sat down, his movement unhurried. He leaned in slightly, eyes skimming over the text.

Phainon didn’t move, though he was keenly aware of the shift in space, of Mydei’s presence now close.

“What is it?” Mydei asked, voice quiet.

Phainon hesitated, then tilted the book just enough for him to see. “Something I found.”

His gaze lingered on EKTHA.

Mydei didn’t comment, but his attention stayed on the page. If he noticed the significance, he didn’t say.

“You got quiet,” he mused instead, his tone light. “Didn’t think you’d get caught up in a book.”

Phainon smirked lazily. “Guess I found something interesting.”

Mydei huffed a soft laugh, his lips curving faintly. “You always do.”

Then, without warning, he took the book from Phainon’s hands and stood.

“Let’s go,” he said again, tone casual but not leaving room for argument. “No need to sit here all night.”

Phainon sighed, rolling his shoulders as he got to his feet, his tail flicking lazily behind him. “You really don’t have patience, do you?”

Mydei was already walking, not bothering to answer.

Phainon shook his head, falling into step beside him.

For a while, neither of them spoke. The silence was comfortable, stretching between them like an old habit.

Then, just as Phainon was slipping back into his thoughts, Mydei exhaled—a quiet, almost absent sound.

“I’ll bring you next time too.”

Phainon didn’t react right away, but something in him settled, just a little.

It wasn’t a grand gesture. Not a promise, not a declaration.

But it was something.

And somehow, that was enough.

A slow smile tugged at Phainon’s lips as he adjusted his pace, falling into stride with Mydei.

Next time.

Maybe that wasn’t so bad.

-

Phainon sprawled across the ground, arms stretched lazily over the cool stone, eyes fixed on the sky. The sun hung high, golden light pouring down in soft waves. A perfect afternoon.

And yet, here he was—stuck outside. Again.

They had arrived at Thalorionis, the underground sanctuary buried beneath the citadel. A place steeped in importance, where names carried weight and decisions shaped the future. But as always, politics had shut him out. Meetings, negotiations, alliances—things that, according to everyone else, had nothing to do with *him*.

So he waited. Alone. Watching the sky, listening to the distant hum of the world moving without him.

Phainon sighed and turned his head, trying to find *something* remotely interesting in the view. But there was only stone, shadows stretching with the slow turn of the sun, and the massive, ancient entrance of Thalorionis looming in the distance.

After a few moments of staring into the light, his eyes started to sting. He blinked rapidly, rubbing at them with the back of his hand.

“Damn,” he muttered. “Guess that’s what I get for trying to have a staring contest with the sun.”

With a grunt, he sat up, brushing the dust from his clothes. The feeling that had followed him since they arrived—something between boredom and frustration—hadn’t faded. If anything, it had settled deeper.

He let himself flop back down with a sigh, not to sleep, just to be. The faint breeze curled around him, carrying distant echoes of movement from within Thalorionis. There was an odd comfort to it, the quiet, the steady pulse of life beneath the surface.

His thoughts drifted.

“Thalorionis,” he murmured, his voice barely above a breath, “stretches for miles underground… practically its own world down there. Entire cities, buried under stone. Like a labyrinth.”

He exhaled slowly, staring up at the sky as his mind wandered.

“Some levels are so old, no one even knows what they were built for… they say there are entire districts that have been sealed off for centuries…”

The words came lazily, unraveling in half-formed thoughts. He wasn’t even sure who he was talking to—maybe just himself, maybe the air, maybe no one at all.

“…Would be nice to see it.”

The thought landed heavier than he expected.

His fingers twitched. His tail flicked once against the ground.

He sat up abruptly.

His gaze locked onto the entrance—ancient stone carved with symbols older than most living memory. Mydei was in there, along with all the others. The ones who belonged there. The ones making decisions, shaping outcomes, moving forward while he sat outside, waiting for permission that would never come.

Phainon clicked his tongue, irritation sparking at the edges of his thoughts.

It wasn’t just curiosity. It wasn’t just boredom.

He wanted in.

He stood, brushing himself off, eyes narrowing as he studied the entrance.

“Maybe just a quick look,” he muttered to himself, licking his lips. A stupid thought, really. But the more he let it sit, the more it felt like the only logical thing to do.

He wasn’t content to sit and wait.

Not today.

Phainon ran a hand through his hair, exhaling slowly as he eyed the entrance to Thalorionis. The structure loomed before him, ancient and unwavering, the stonework etched with markings older than most civilizations. No guards, no patrols. Just two massive sentinels carved from obsidian and veined with something that pulsed faintly beneath the surface.

He recognized them immediately. *Astrothes*. The Unyielding Witnesses.

Legends claimed they had been shaped by the first architects of Thalorionis, their purpose singular—to judge. Not by choice, not by bias, but by an unwavering, incorruptible truth. Their gaze could strip away all deception, reducing the unworthy to nothing more than dust on the threshold.

And *he* was very much unworthy.

Phainon clicked his tongue, folding his arms as he studied them. Their eyes—deep, faceted crystal set into their unmoving faces—glowed faintly, a silent reminder that purity was the only currency accepted here.

Which meant he needed to cheat.

He wasn’t the only one unable to enter. Thalorionis wasn’t just a sacred ground; it was submerged in anatevrian waters, the kind that recognized only the unstained. The devout, the righteous. Unfortunately, that list didn’t include him.

But it also didn’t include a good number of others—envoys, scribes, lesser nobility. And for them, there were *relics*.

Phainon’s lips curled into a slow smirk. *That’ll do.*

Now, he just had to find one.

He stepped away from the entrance, scanning the gathering outside. Not everyone had been granted immediate access. There were always people

lingering—some waiting, some whispering amongst themselves, some clearly frustrated by the restrictions.

And then he spotted his mark.

A younger man, robed in deep blue, fingers curled tightly around a small pendant at his throat. Nervous, pacing, muttering under his breath. The way he kept glancing toward the entrance and adjusting the chain around his neck told Phainon everything he needed to know.

That's it.

He straightened, slipping into a more composed stance, expression smoothing into something gentler, more refined. He didn't look like an incubi. Snow-white hair, blue eyes—if anything, he carried the features of something closer to an angel, if not for the way he usually carried himself. But now, he could make use of it.

Adopting an air of quiet grace, he approached, careful to move with a presence that suggested authority without outright demanding it. The young man barely noticed him at first, too caught up in his own frustrations.

Phainon tilted his head, voice calm, almost sympathetic. "Trouble getting in?"

The man startled slightly, looking up. "Ah—yes. I—" He hesitated, then exhaled sharply. "The Astrothes haven't acknowledged my entrance yet."

Phainon's gaze flicked briefly to the relic at the man's throat before returning to his face. "Unfortunate."

The man huffed, clearly distressed. "I was *assured* this would work. My family has long held ties with Thalorionis—there shouldn't be any issue."

Phainon offered a slow nod, as if in understanding. Then, with just the right amount of curiosity, he asked, "May I?"

The man blinked, confused. "May you…?"

Phainon gestured subtly to the relic. “Your pendant. If it’s meant to grant passage, there may be a way to reinforce its presence. Sometimes the anatevrian waters resist weak blessings. I’ve seen it before.”

A blatant lie, but he delivered it with such quiet confidence that the man hesitated only a moment before nodding and undoing the clasp.

The second it was in Phainon’s hands, he acted.

A brief shift of fingers, a subtle flick of movement—and the pendant was his.

He returned a different chain, similar enough in weight and feel that the man wouldn’t immediately notice. Then, with a reassuring smile, Phainon placed a hand on his shoulder. “Give it a moment. The Astrothes will recognize it soon.”

The man looked relieved, nodding quickly as he stepped toward the entrance once more.

Phainon turned before he could see the deception unravel.

With the stolen relic now safely in his grasp, he moved toward the threshold, slipping the pendant over his head. The cool metal rested against his skin, a faint hum resonating through it.

This was it.

Taking a breath, he stepped forward.

The Astrothes remained still, their crystal eyes locking onto him. For a split second, a terrible silence filled the space between them, the pressure of judgment creeping in.

Phainon didn’t falter. He kept his pace steady, his expression neutral.

Then—

The glow in their eyes dimmed.

They did not move. They did not reject him.

The relic had done its job.

Phainon stepped past them, feeling the shift in the air, the sensation of crossing from one world into another.

And just like that—

He was in.

Chapter End Notes

> Next chapter should be posted tomorrow? Sorry for the late update on this, I know this is probably REALLY self indulgent but again this is like the only fic I’ve ever done without an outline☹
>
> I’ve been lacking behind in my writers quota of 5-10k words so I’ll make that up later in future fics and this one please believe me😭😭

Chapter 4: Notes from a Doomed Familiar

Chapter Summary

> Phainon sneaks into an underwater god-city, eats questionable immortal street food, accidentally joins a sacred duel, bleeds the wrong color, gets caught by the Goddess of Romance, and ends up grounded in the divine council's murder basement while Mydei silently questions all his life choices.

Chapter Notes

> Well, looks like Myphai won😍 Smut I'm guessing I'll add on chapter 6? Speaking of, after I finish this fic and chapter 11 of my superhero fic, I have literally the BEST multi chaptered Myphai fic lined up that I'm excited even talking abt it😭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon stepped through the threshold, and the world changed.

Light bent around him, impossibly bright, filtered through sapphire waters. What lay beyond the gates of Thalorionis wasn't a city—it was a legend, alive and breathing. Great coral palaces stretched high into the depths, their spiraling towers woven from living reef and stone, crowned with glass domes that shimmered like trapped stars. Sanctuaries floated between them, suspended by thin currents of light, tethered only by strands of woven kelp and ancient incantations.

The streets glittered beneath his feet, paved in crushed pearl and tempered glass. Above, aqueducts of crystalline water arched through the open spaces, carrying shimmering schools of fish and streaks of bioluminescent flora. The very air hummed, thick with old seals and protective rites meant to keep things like him out—a persistent pressure against his skin, like a thousand hands trying to push him away.

If not for the relic hanging loosely around his neck, he was certain he'd be a smear on the polished stones by now.

He took a breath—sharp, cold, too clean. It didn't taste like air. It tasted like something long untouched by corruption or grief, and it made his stomach twist in a way he didn't care to dwell on.

Gods, it was beautiful.

Phainon let out a slow whistle, running a hand through his pale hair as his gaze tracked the layers of life moving through the place. Purveyor's balanced trays of glimmering offerings, robed figures spoke in lilting chants, and statues too perfect to be mortal lined every street corner, their expressions caught forever between sorrow and joy.

A place like this shouldn't exist.

And yet here it was—and here *he* was, standing in its heart like he belonged.

"Well," Phainon muttered to no one in particular, a crooked grin tugging at his lips. "Guess they'll let anyone in these days."

The pulse of wards and spells prickled at his skin as he moved deeper into the city, but the relic did its work. The pressure faded to a dull thrum at the base of his skull, leaving only awe in its wake. He didn't even try to hide it—the wide eyes, the way his head tilted to track the ghostly glow of a sea serpent as it wound lazily past a temple spire.

It was a miracle.

And for once, Phainon wasn't in a rush to ruin it.

Phainon stretched his arms over his head, rolling the tension from his shoulders as he took in the impossible sprawl of Thalorionis. No wonder the old texts spoke of it like a lost Eden. The entire city moved like a living thing—coral towers shifting with the slow pulse of the deep, bridges of translucent stone breathing faintly beneath his feet, and great sanctums

suspended by chains of woven starlight, drifting in the currents like sunken moons.

There were no merchants hawking wares or common stalls cluttering the streets like in the mortal world. Here, trade happened through unspoken gestures and exchanges of essence. Glass reliquaries hung between archways, each containing fragments of light, strands of woven memory, or shimmering beads of condensed song. Offerings passed hands without a word. It wasn't about price, though.

The economy of Thalorionis, as it turned out, was built on blood—both figuratively and otherwise. The pure-blooded, those descended from celestial lines or born beneath the veil of the Titans, possessed an innate right to claim whatever they desired. Their virtue alone was considered currency, their very presence a tithe to the city's hallowed grounds. The sanctified scrolls called it Anaktora Dorea, the Gift of Sovereigns—the belief that those born flawless were the living embodiment of providence itself, and to deny them was to deny the natural order.

For everyone else?

A drop of blood.

A sacred cut at the wrist or fingertip, given freely into consecrated vessels. It wasn't payment, not by their standards—it was offering. A blessing in disguise. The vitae shed was said to bind the supplicant closer to the divine waters, cleansing mortal fault and making one known to the city itself. So the priests claimed.

To Phainon, it was mostly inconvenient.

He absently palmed one of the slim coins hidden in his sleeve, the metal cool against his skin. Relics like the one around his neck could bypass most of the formalities, their blessings ancient enough to permit material currency. Technically. It wasn't exactly illegal. Just… *distasteful*. A stranger using forged blessings and weightless gold in a place where even a whisper of corruption could sour the water.

Not that it stopped him.

When no one was looking, he slipped a coin into a floating basin cradled by a figure of bleached stone, snagged a cluster of sun-dried lotus petals dusted with stardust resin, and popped one into his mouth with a sharp grin.

Sweet. Crisp. Nothing like surface food. Every bite felt radiant, like eating preserved light.

He took his time wandering through the towering halls and delicate causeways, watching as plumes of bioluminescent mist curled from the mouths of carved leviathans, and streams of mirrored fish spun like threads through the open domes. Somewhere above, a choir of unseen voices sang a wordless hymn, and for a moment, the city felt less like a place and more like a dream someone had forgotten to wake from.

Phainon tilted his head back, letting the glow of the sun through the water bathe his face, and smiled to himself.

“Well,” he muttered under his breath, “could be worse.”

And with that, he moved deeper into Thalorionis, eager to see what else the so-called paradise had to offer before someone figured out he had no business being there.

Phainon didn’t mean to start devouring everything in sight—it just kind of happened.

It began innocently enough: a passing tray of something that looked like spun glass, delicate threads of iridescent silk coiled into the shape of a blossom. He didn’t even ask what it was. Just snatched one up when no one was looking and bit in. It dissolved on his tongue like frost, leaving behind the taste of honeyed sea-salt and something almost floral, something that made the back of his throat tingle.

From there, it spiraled.

He wandered between open sanctums and vaulted galleries, snagging whatever looked edible—shimmering fruits that bled liquid starlight when bitten into, tiny spheres of chilled nectar that floated in the air until you caught them with your teeth, roasted petals glazed in thick, sun-golden syrup.

At one point, he passed a vessel made of crystal coral, inside which lay what appeared to be a single, perfect oyster, its shell lined in opal. A passing attendant in a trailing, pale robe gave him a bemused glance when he reached for it, but made no move to stop him.

Phainon grinned and knocked it back like a shot.

Mistake.

The texture was all wrong. Like drinking liquid velvet while chewing on something that might have once been a flower. The taste? Sharp and freezing, then cloyingly sweet, like biting through frost into molten honey. His eyes watered. His stomach lurched. He swallowed it anyway.

“Alright,” he rasped, voice rough, “probably not for surface dwellers.”

A few of the pure-blooded onlookers—dressed in whisper-thin silk and draped in relic-threaded jewels—watched him with polite wariness, a few arching pale brows when he flicked another coin into a basin to pay for a piece of what looked like glazed tidefruit. Phainon could practically feel their judgment, subtle and cold like mist against his skin.

No one said a word, though. Which was a marked improvement compared to the usual jeering contempt he got back home, where every side-eye and muttered remark around the Council chambers came with a reminder that he was either a charity case, a mistake, or worse.

Here, at least, no one knew his name. They just thought he was an odd angel with bad table manners.

He could live with that.

By the time he reached a massive, tiered fountain where glowing syrup cascaded down like molten glass, Phainon's stomach ached in a way it hadn't in years. None of this was *real* sustenance for him—not the kind his body craved. But gods, it tasted good. And after a while, that was enough.

He snatched a skewer of something blistered and glazed from a passing silver dish—some kind of sea-creature, charred until the flesh crackled under his teeth and smoked when he bit in—and grunted in approval.

A few nearby purebloods shot him scandalized looks at the sheer *feralness* of his eating habits, one murmuring something in a liquid, ancient tongue that Phainon didn't bother deciphering. He winked at them, wiped his mouth with the back of his hand, and grabbed another.

Maybe he'd die from one of these things. Maybe not.

Either way, he was *eating good tonight.*

Phainon was elbow-deep in something that probably wasn't meant to be eaten by creatures born of shadow and spite, but at this point, he'd given up trying to figure out what half the shimmering dishes even were. The food here was impossible—petal-thin wafers that dissolved into warmth and light on his tongue, spiced broths that shimmered with constellations, fruits that bled silver nectar. He didn't care what any of it was. He was starving, and the taste was *unreal*.

The configurer, a tall figure whose face flickered like water catching light, shot him a suspicious glance as he slipped a few coins onto the offering dish. The act earned a faint sniff of disdain, but no words. Fine by him. At least no one here was throwing him through a wall or hissing about him sullying their sacred halls.

He reached for something that looked like a skewer of candied storm pearls when a tiny hand suddenly tugged at the edge of his sleeve.

Phainon blinked down.

A child. Or… something like one. Its skin shimmered opalescent, eyes wide and the color of dawn breaking over the sea. An Archon fledgling, judging by the faint flicker of sigils hovering around its brow. No older than seven or eight by human standards—which meant probably older than him, in some twisted cosmic sense.

The kid just stared at him, expression solemn and awed.

“Are you…” the child whispered, voice soft as ripples on glass. “One of the Choir?”

Phainon choked slightly on a bite of something unnervingly delicious. “Me? Uh—yeah. Totally. One of those. Choir boy, through and through.” He grinned, a little too sharp.

The child brightened, clapping tiny hands together in glee. “Mama says when the Aetheris light touches down, the Choir sends one to watch over us.”

Before he could stop it—or object, or run—the kid raised a hand, delicate fingers glowing with the warm, iridescent shimmer of a benediction.

“By the Veiled Crown and Light of the Starborn Depths, I offer you grace.”

Oh, shit.

A sharp, warm jolt struck him in the chest. It wasn’t like flame—no, this was *clean.* Light without shadow, so bright it made his stomach knot. For a split second, his skin prickled and his breath hitched—relic working overtime, the buffer between his cursed nature and divine power barely holding.

And then it was over.

The kid smiled, patted his hand, and skipped off like nothing had happened.

Phainon stood frozen for a beat, pulse hammering. He exhaled slowly, muttering under his breath, “That… could’ve been worse.”

He turned—and immediately noticed several nearby purebloods and retainers watching him with mild reverence. A few even inclined their heads. One of the older ones murmured something about “Celestine favor.”

Phainon gave them his most beatific, holier-than-thou smile. “Blessings upon you all,” he purred, then promptly bolted down the next street before anyone could get a better look.

Phainon rounded the corner, ducking beneath the arch of a half-crumbling coral overpass and weaving into a narrow, dim-lit alcove tucked between two shrines slick with bioluminescent moss. Only when he was out of sight did he let the holy grin drop off his face like a mask snapping loose.

He dropped to his knees in a harsh *thud*, a ragged gasp tearing from his throat.

Fuck.

It hit him all at once—the air, the residual blessing clinging to his skin like frostbite, the searing ache in his chest. His head tipped back against the cool stone, throat working as he sucked in air that felt like knives.

What the *hell* was he doing?

Sneaking into Thalorionis during the Month of Aetheris? Getting *blessed* by some fledgling Archon? Smiling at purebloods like he belonged here?

He barked out a hoarse, humorless laugh that immediately choked off into a groan as another pang tore through his stomach—not hunger for food, but something worse. An ache gnawing at the marrow of him.

It wasn’t like he hadn’t felt it before—every year when the stars aligned and the holy light of Aetheris drowned the skies and seas, incubi and their kind crawled into whatever shadows they could find to wait it out. The Month of Aetheris wasn’t for them. It was for renewal, for blessing, for the God’s bloodline.

And for people like him, it was a curse.

He’d been holding out for weeks, avoiding the itch, the hollow pit in his gut that no food or light could fill. And now—surrounded by pureblood familiars, holy air thick as syrup, divine seals woven into every crack of the city—it came rushing in like a wave, crashing down and dragging him under.

He gritted his teeth, shoving a hand through his hair. It stuck to his forehead, damp with cold sweat.

“Okay, okay, you’re fine,” he muttered. “This is fine. This is… fine adjacent.”

His stomach twisted again, and he curled in on himself briefly, pressing his palm flat to the stone floor, letting the cool bite of it anchor him.

I should leave. I should get the fuck out.

Except he couldn’t. Not yet. Not without drawing attention. Not with the city guards still prowling the upper levels and those damn stone wardens at the exits.

And not while his relic’s buffer was still holding.

He took a breath, slower this time. The ache didn’t ease, but it dulled to something manageable—barely.

“Alright,” he rasped to the empty alley, dragging himself to his feet with a grimace. “One more loop around. No weird holy kids. No more free blessings. No duels. Just… keep your head down, dumbass.”

It wasn’t the best plan.

But he’d made worse.

Phainon forced himself upright.

It wasn’t graceful. His limbs felt too long, his skin too tight, a pulse beneath it that didn’t belong to him. The polished stone walls shimmered faintly around him, halos of light bending and twitching at the edges of his vision.

His reflection in a water-veiled archway caught his eye—pale skin a little too bloodless now, those sharp blue eyes clouded with something inky swimming just beneath the surface. His lips quirked in a bitter grin. He looked like a ghost, or worse, one of them.

Rein it in. Pull yourself together.

Phainon swallowed hard, ignoring the way his throat felt raw as he straightened his shoulders and set one foot ahead of the other. Each step felt jagged, his bones scraping together like ill-fitted clockwork, but he moved. He could pretend. He always could.

Walk. Think. Find a way out.

Astrothes still stood at the city's front—those stone monstrosities weren't moving for anyone. And his relic's trick wouldn't hold long if anyone else got too curious.

His path took him through an open courtyard, the kind built for no reason other than to humble lesser beings. Enormous coral pillars wreathed in bioluminescent vines reached up to the domed ceiling above, and a soft, shimmering mist hung in the air like some sacred veil.

He should've kept walking.

But his feet stopped.

He heard it before he truly saw it—the low hum of energy, the sharp clash of steel, and the unearthly *thrumm* of sigils flaring mid-air.

A Duel of Aetheris.

Shit.

Even in a place like this, it was rare to see one up close. The Month of Aetheris wasn't all sunshine and rainbows—it was tradition. Gods and their highest familiars clashed in ritual combat, offerings of strength, light, and loyalty spilled across consecrated grounds.

It took him a second to realize what he was actually looking at.

These weren’t mortals.

They weren’t even lesser divine.

No—the way the air around them crackled, how the ground itself shimmered at their feet, marked them for what they were.

High familiars.

Born from the rivers of fate. From the breath of storm titans. From light made manifest.

Phainon’s stomach twisted viciously.

The ache wasn’t dull anymore. It gnawed at him, curling cold fingers up his spine and latching onto the base of his skull. His vision hazed, edges of the world blurring and warping in sickly hues. He could smell it—the sanctity radiating off them in waves, a sickly-sweet thing that made his head swim.

His kind wasn’t meant to be here. His blood didn’t belong in this light.

And his own nature, that deep, crawling *hunger*, was waking up.

He pressed a palm hard to his chest, felt the thrum of his pulse—too fast, too sharp.

“*Keep moving…*” he hissed under his breath, forcing his legs to take a step. Then another. Each one a battle in itself.

But against his better judgment, his eyes were still locked on the dueling grounds. The sigils, the elegance of the fight, the raw power. It was intoxicating in the worst way.

And somewhere, far too close for comfort, someone was looking his way.

He knew before he even met their gaze.

And for the first time in hours, Phainon’s smile returned—sharp, reckless, and entirely too amused.

“Well,” he muttered, “guess I’m *fucked*.”

Phainon’s pace quickened.

The ache in his chest hadn’t dulled—it had sharpened, fine and exacting as a blade. The further he tried to drag himself from the courtyard, the heavier the air grew around him, thick with the sacred weight of consecration, of rites older than the ground beneath his feet.

And then—*it found him.*

A sensation like sunlight breaking through storm clouds, holy and ancient, swept over his skin, tightening his throat. It wasn’t warmth. It wasn’t even light. It was a suffocating presence, absolute and inescapable.

He stiffened before he even turned.

“Incandescent one,” came a voice, clear and unshaken, as though spoken from the lips of a statue in a long-forgotten shrine.

Phainon grit his teeth, turned with an ease he didn’t feel.

There stood a figure draped in robes of shifting opalescence, woven with threads of starlight and mist. No weapon in hand—they didn’t need one. A radiant circlet hovered above their brow, not resting, but orbiting like a captured moon. Their hair was the color of sun-bleached bone, eyes fathomless pools of liquid silver.

A familiar he knew by reputation alone.

Cyneides of Aegiros, the Pale Grace. Born of the Fifth Vein of the Skywater. Companion to Astraion, God of Dawn’s Passing. They had walked these realms since the rivers first carved paths through stone and light. There wasn’t a creature in the pantheon who hadn’t heard their name.

Phainon schooled his expression into something pleasant, though his stomach twisted.

“Cyneides,” he greeted, inclining his head with the kind of reverence expected of someone of *lesser station.*

And wasn’t that always the damn way of it?

Sometimes—fleetingly, never for long—he wondered what it might’ve been like. If he hadn’t been what he was. If the threads of fate hadn’t knotted him to *Mydei*, or if he’d been born of something clean, of water or light or stars. Not stolen breath and half-lit places.

The thought came and went, a flicker, a phantom itch beneath his ribs.

He let it pass, like he always did.

“You shine strangely,” Cyneides murmured, gaze assessing. “There is divinity upon you, yet no origin I know. An unusual star, fallen among the others.”

“I get that a lot.”

A faint smile. A humorless thing.

Cyneides stepped closer. Phainon fought not to flinch. Every instinct screamed *run*, but ancient, unwritten law demanded deference.

“A Duel of Aetheris is underway,” the Pale Grace continued, gesturing to the grounds behind them. “The honor of the blessed to answer the call when summoned.” Their gaze lingered on him. “Come.”

It wasn’t a request.

Refusing would be worse.

Phainon’s throat worked around a dry swallow. A thousand excuses bloomed and died on his tongue. His mind reeled, bile sharp at the back of his throat—but he managed a smile, sharp-edged and reckless.

“Wouldn’t dream of declining.”

The words tasted like ash.

Cyneides turned, the faintest glimmer of satisfaction in their expression. Phainon followed, every step a fight against the part of him that howled in protest.

He tucked the envy, the fear, the hunger deep, behind the old grin that had gotten him through worse nights.

Alright, you bastard, he thought to himself, *let’s see how much of a mess you can make before they figure out what you are.*

And with that, the courtyard swallowed him whole.

Phainon followed in Cyneides’ wake, the courtyard beyond wasn’t some orderly dueling ring, nor a simple gathering of combatants. It was *alive*—a shifting sprawl of sacred violence, divine elegance, and ancient rites tangled into one.

There were no neat queues, no idle spectators in stands. Instead, beings gathered like storms, coalescing in natural clusters of light and color and sound. Familiar sigils shimmered overhead, ever-shifting, ancient crests and seals Phainon dimly recalled from half-read texts and drunken lectures. The emblem of Aethelogon, whose blade was said to have split the first mountain. The spiral of Nyxaris, keeper of the obsidian moons. He caught sight of the twin suns of Caeronis, the legend who single-handedly quelled the Sea of Souls.

The air reeked of old power.

Phainon passed duels already underway—though none resembled the crude brawls of mortal men. Fighters moved like silk and shadow, their blades singing, bodies wreathed in light, ichor casting sparks as it hit consecrated stone. Some duels played out in complete silence, others accompanied by choirs of unseen voices. One pair fought knee-deep in suspended water that

clung to them like mercury, while another traded strikes mid-air, wingbeats sounding like thunderclaps.

He paused as he passed a familiar name—Tharos of Lethe—locked in a circling bout with Veyne the Hollow, a wraith-like figure rumored to have been born from the grief of a dying god. Their swords moved in intricate, almost reverent patterns, neither seeming eager to land the first strike, as if the duel itself was the true offering.

And despite himself, despite the gnawing ache and the too-tight relic searing against his skin, Phainon allowed a tired smile.

“Well… if I’m already doomed,” he murmured under his breath, “might as well enjoy the show.”

He trailed his gaze up to the skyless dome overhead, where shimmering vaults of bioluminescent clouds swirled like painted gods watching from above, and allowed himself a brief, unguarded moment of awe.

Thalorionis.

What a cursedly beautiful place to die.

By the time an indeterminate number of duels had passed—though really, what even was time in a place like this—Phainon was internally screaming.

He’d been stuck orbiting the bloodless, holy chaos for what felt like *years*. The so-called friendly sparring never seemed to stop. No one here ran out of breath. No one tired. Limbs moved like storm winds, strikes landed with the force of falling constellations, and still, no one even looked winded.

What the fuck are they on? Phainon thought, barely suppressing the urge to start gnawing at his own knuckles. The aching hunger in his chest had dulled to something raw and ancient, the kind of bone-deep craving even Incubi weren’t meant to endure for long—and still, he forced a languid, indifferent smirk onto his face.

He’d been doing his best to stay behind the bigger names, avoiding any match-ups, finding excuses about observing styles and “assessing potential threats” whenever someone got too curious. It worked. Barely.

But even Phainon knew this wasn’t sustainable. Sooner or later, someone important was going to call him out, and relic or not, if they figured out what he actually was, he’d be thrown to the Astrothes at the gate, stripped of whatever name remained of him, and left to rot in some half-flooded ruin.

And then, like a gift from whichever petty, spiteful god might be listening, it came to him.

He remembered an old tradition. One of those dusty, ancient customs half these relic-blooded zealots still held sacred. **“The Rite of Aristeion’s Mercy.”** Sounded pretty, sounded noble—but essentially, it meant if a duelist bested a chosen opponent *named for the hour*, they could invoke the rite to step down and be granted an early departure, free of offense.

The trick was, the hour’s chosen changed constantly, based on the position of the Aether lamps overhead. One look told him it had shifted to Veyne the Hollow, not someone most would volunteer to spar with.

But for Phainon, it was either that or bleed black in front of a divine audience.

“Well then,” he sighed, stretching his arms over his head and cracking his neck. His bones felt too light, his skin too tight—like his own hunger was scraping at his insides with hooked nails. Still, his grin sharpened.

He licked his lips, tasting salt and something metallic.

“Time to work.”

With as much swagger as his exhausted, half-cursed form could muster, Phainon stepped forward, offering a casual bow as if this was all a joke he was about to play at someone else’s expense.

“Veyne, darling,” he called, voice like silk over a dagger’s edge. “I believe it’s your hour.”

There was a faint hush—not a sudden stillness, no dramatic halt of the duels around them, but a collective pause in tempo. The kind of intangible shift only gods and those born too close to the divine could sense. Like the turning of a vast, invisible eye.

Veyne, draped in layered silk that shimmered like frostbitten mist, tilted their head toward him. Pale, near-translucent features unreadable, the air around them glimmered faintly, warping like heat haze.

They repeated the word softly, like tasting it.

“Darling…?”

Not anger. Just curiosity, as if Phainon had spoken a word from a long-dead tongue.

Phainon smiled wider, not because he meant it, but because instinct made him dangerous when cornered. He rolled his wrist, adopting a languid duelist’s stance—crooked but balanced, weight on the balls of his feet. The aching in his bones went ignored.

“Your hour,” he said. “Let’s make it interesting.”

Veyne didn’t move. They didn’t have to. The space around them *folded*. The pearlescent light warped, and then they were no longer standing across the courtyard *but in front of him*—a flicker, a shiver of something ancient pressing against Phainon’s skin like a storm tide.

Good gods, he thought. *No wonder no one volunteers.*

Then everything happened at once.

Veyne moved, an arc of their wrist, and the ground beneath Phainon splintered—not stone but light itself, shattering in jagged shards. Phainon ducked low, a flare of searing white slicing the air where his throat had

been, kicking off from the cracked pearl-dust flooring and launching himself sideways.

He hit the ground, rolled, and came up with a burst of momentum, fingertips skimming the ground to launch himself forward. His body screamed against the motion—hunger, exhaustion, fraying relic charms all threatening to give—but muscle memory had always been his most loyal sin.

His shoulder collided with Veyne mid-strike. A ripple of energy burst out, both of them thrown apart by the sheer backlash.

Phainon landed hard, spat out a curse, and drew a line in the air with two fingers. Sparks followed. A trick Mydei hated when he used—too reckless, too crude—but it worked.

The spark ignited the thin layer of sanctified mist between them into a burst of hissing light. It wouldn't wound Veyne, but it obscured him long enough for Phainon to dart close, strike low at their leg, then pivot away, avoiding the retaliating sweep of a shimmering sleeve that cut through the space like a blade.

The crowd stirred, voices rising, not cheering—this wasn't that kind of duel—but murmuring in approval.

Phainon grinned, blood tasting like iron at the back of his throat.

Veyne appeared again, sudden as thought, a whisper of cloth and cold radiance. A palm thrust toward his chest—a strike that would unmake lesser things.

Phainon twisted, felt the hit graze his ribs, pressure cracking something inside. His vision flashed black at the edges. Didn't matter.

He caught Veyne's wrist as they passed, using the momentum to spin them both, slamming a knee up into their midsection. Not much force behind it—like kicking smoke—but enough to stagger.

He pounced, hands finding purchase on the ethereal, half-real form and driving them down in a sweep, sending both tumbling.

They landed, breathless. Phainon's hand was at Veyne's throat—not a killing grip, but enough to count.

"I yield the hour," Veyne murmured, serene as water.

Phainon didn't release immediately, panting, his own heartbeat thunderous in his skull. Then, reluctantly, he let go, pushing himself upright on unsteady legs. The ache in his gut was worse now, black spots dancing behind his eyes.

The duels hadn't stopped. The gods didn't pause for long. But a few glances marked him now—a few knowing looks.

Veyne, impossibly, smiled.

"Well fought, angel-born."

Phainon forced a smile. "I get to leave now, right?"

Veyne gave a shallow nod, vanishing in a ripple of cold light.

And Phainon straightened, pain and victory mingling bitterly in his chest. Now, all he had to do was make it to the gates without collapsing.

Phainon moved through the thinning courtyard flexing his fingers once, twice, adjusting the relic's weight against his chest—the charm flickering faintly, threads of foreign light pulsing with each breath he took.

A satisfied grin tugged at his lips.

For the first time in what felt like forever, they had stared at him.

Not in revulsion. Not in veiled contempt. Not as a shadow trailing behind some greater thing. No—recognition. Measured. Appraising.

It hit him a few paces after he started walking. Subtle, but sharp.

They saw me.

And damn it, it felt good.

Not enough to fix anything, but enough to make his steps a little lighter, shoulders a little straighter as he ambled toward the nearest archway leading to the outer causeways. He was already working out half a dozen escape routes in his head, each more impossible than the last, but optimism was a dangerous and addictive thing when you hadn't tasted it in years.

"Alright," he muttered under his breath, hands in his pockets, dodging a cluster of Aetherborn glassfish darting overhead, "maybe a clean break through the lower sanctum. Nobody bothers checking relic signatures down there. Worst case, swim it. Hope the Astrothes are still on their millennia nap."

A self-amused chuckle slipped past his lips. His humor was usually all teeth, sharp and defensive, but now it was loose. Actual amusement.

He tipped his head back, stretching, feeling his spine pop satisfyingly, when the air shifted.

Not dramatically. Not the crashing silence of divine wrath.

Just colder.

A thin, invisible thread of frost trailing down his spine. The kind of feeling you got when walking into a room you swore was empty—but someone's already inside.

His stride didn't break. If anything, it got a little more careless.

Never show it.

That was lesson one.

The cold settled. Stayed. Every instinct in him begged to glance over his shoulder, but instead, he yawned, rubbing at the side of his face, palm dragging down the curve of his cheek lazily.

And then he felt it.

Wet.

Warm.

Brows furrowing, Phainon let his hand drop to eye level. Blinked.

A smear of black across his fingers. Viscous. Iridescent in the soft light, tinged faintly violet where it caught the shimmer of the sanctified mist overhead.

Blood.

And not just any blood.

His blood.

Black.

Time cracked open.

For one terrible, beautiful moment, the world shrank to the space between his heartbeat and the next. He couldn’t remember getting hit. Couldn’t remember bleeding. But it didn’t matter.

Because this wasn’t supposed to happen.

Not here.

Not now.

His heart gave a painful, stuttering lurch against his ribs.

Shit.

The blood still shimmered on his fingertips.

A memory of all those watching eyes slid back into his mind, and this time it wasn’t recognition of a peer. It was recognition of a mistake. A wrong thing.

Phainon swallowed, throat dry.

The cold deepened.

And now, *now*, it was time to run.

The air—if you could even call it that, this consecrated weight of divine mists and ancient salt—pressed heavy against his skin.

Okay. Okay. No one saw. No one saw.

His fingers curled into a fist, smearing the dark stain across his palm.

It was fine. He’d been sweating, right? Old bruises, old cuts—this place was a hazard for mortals anyway. Maybe it wasn’t even his. Maybe—

A bead of sweat slid down the side of his temple.

He didn’t wipe it.

Instead, with the casual care of someone who absolutely wasn’t two seconds from internally losing his shit, Phainon turned, took a slow step toward the nearest side passage. A smooth, gleaming corridor of polished coral and pale-light glyphs, leading deeper into the tiered sanctums.

He kept his head down. Not slouched—never slouched—but unremarkable. Forgettable. One face in a city of myths.

Another step.

The air was a knife against his skin now, the thin hum of old enchantments brushing against the relic at his throat like searching fingers.

The sigils along the arches he passed flickered.

Only for a moment.

He almost missed it.

His stomach dropped.

No one saw.

He repeated it like a prayer, though it tasted sour in his mouth.

And then—

A soft, wet *drip* echoed onto the pearlescent floor.

He didn’t look.

Didn’t need to.

Another drop followed.

And another.

Phainon’s pulse thundered in his ears.

A few feet ahead, a slender figure veiled in streaming silver silk paused, as if catching a scent on the air. They turned their head, pale irises glinting like twin moons. A hush fell over the mist.

Not silence.

A hush.

The kind you felt more than heard.

Like the deep pressure before a storm breaks open.

Phainon swore under his breath. A sharp, ugly sound.

Time to go.

He pivoted on his heel—and something cold brushed the back of his neck. Not a hand. Not a blade. Something worse. He doesn’t dare look back.

The remnants of old fear from darker days, sewn deep into his marrow, came screaming to the surface. His breath hitched. Every instinct he’d buried for years, polished into civility and smirking nonchalance, cracked open.

He ran.

Not a sprint.

A calculated, clean break.

Fluid, almost casual, as though he was simply moving faster because he had somewhere to be.

He slipped down a narrow corridor flanked by towering statues of drowned titans, each one cloaked in salt-crusted chains.

The mist churned behind him.

He didn’t look back.

Wouldn’t.

His teeth clenched. His pulse was a frantic snare beat in his skull.

“Shit, shit, shit—” he hissed between clenched teeth, sliding one hand into his coat for the dagger hilt at his hip, more a charm than a weapon in a place like this.

Another pulse of cold.

This time, it came with a voice.

Soft. Silk-draped. Amused.

“Leaving so soon?”

And just like that—

The world cracked open.

Golden threads.

Not strands. Not silk.

Not rope.

Threads.

Fine as mist, gleaming like the first light of dawn, searing where they touched skin—they snapped into place around Phainon's frame before he could take another step.

A low, wordless hum filled the corridor. The air grew impossibly heavier, the very marrow of the sanctum responding. Even the mist stilled, as though it, too, knew better.

And then she was there.

Aglaea.

Descending like a sunbeam fractured through ancient waters, her presence more felt than seen at first—a warmth that wasn't warmth, a weight of divinity so clean and composed it made other gods seem like petulant children clamoring for attention.

Her voice followed. Smooth. Calm. But edged like a dagger drawn in quiet halls.

"You disappoint me, Phainon."

A simple statement.

No dramatics.

No raised voice.

But it landed like a blow.

Phainon froze, tension locked tight across his shoulders. A muscle twitched in his jaw as he lifted his chin—the mask slipping back into place with practiced ease.

He grinned.

Not too wide.

“Disappointment? I was aiming for mild inconvenience, actually. Should’ve known I’d overshoot.”

His tone was light, breezy—but it rang hollow even to him. The cold sweat beneath his collar betrayed him, as did the tightness behind his eyes.

Aglaea stepped closer, the threads tightening just enough to remind him they could crush him into ash at a thought.

But they didn’t.

Her lips quirked. Barely.

The faintest ghost of a smile, though it held no warmth.

“I should leave you to the Astrothes,” she mused, as though considering a troublesome child’s punishment. “Or better yet… Tartarus’ archons would love to hear your explanation.”

A bead of sweat slid down Phainon’s neck.

He swallowed.

“Not that I wouldn’t cherish a scenic trip to the Pit, but… given the circumstances, I was hoping for something a little less eternal torment-y. You know. A firm lecture. Maybe a ceremonial flogging. I’m flexible.”

He forced another grin, but his gaze didn’t quite meet hers.

Because behind the humor—behind every flicker of deflection and wit—sat that cold, ugly thing.

The weight of what he was.

Not a god. Not a hero.

An incubi. A familiar. The kind of creature most gods spat at in passing.

But tethered to the only name he'd ever wanted to follow.

And now they all knew.

That ancient, sour sting curled low in his gut. He hated how easy it was to feel it. To remember what it meant, here, of all places.

Aglaea's gaze softened by a fraction—not pity. Never pity.

Something else.

She raised a hand, fingers brushing the air. The threads loosened.

"You'll get no Tartarus, Phainon," she said quietly. "I have something far more fitting in mind."

She turned, the threads drawing him effortlessly after, like a puppet on golden string.

And though his chest ached and his pride stung raw, he found—despite everything—he was almost relieved it had been her.

Anyone else, and he wouldn't be breathing.

And that's how he ended up here.

Phainon sat slumped in his seat, shoulders hunched like a kid hauled before the village elder for stealing the ceremonial wine—except swap 'elder' for

a room full of living myths who could obliterate stars with a passing thought.

This was the Agnostherion.

The Place of Unmasking.

A sanctum few ever saw, and none left unchanged. The vaulted dome above shimmered like an overturned night sky, constellations lazily drifting through misty air. Lightless braziers burned silver flame, and the thrones weren't just seats—they were monuments, each etched with names the world no longer dared speak aloud.

And sitting upon them were the ones responsible for *making history happen.*

Phainon could feel them watching him.

Not cruelly, not even with disdain.

Just the weight of beings so ancient, so vast, that existing near them felt like standing at the edge of a cliff, staring into eternity.

And there, at the highest seat—not in judgment, but in cold disbelief—sat Mydei.

Not scowling. Not furious.

Just staring.

The Crown Prince of Heaven's gaze was a thing Phainon had grown accustomed to over the years. Usually sharp with dry amusement or heavy with fond, exhausted patience.

Right now?

It was an expression caught somewhere between *what the actual fuck are you doing here* and *how did you survive long enough to get caught?*

Phainon felt himself sink lower in his chair, heat prickling under his skin. It wasn’t fear—not with Mydei. Never with him.

It was *mortification*.

Because if it were anyone else, he could’ve laughed it off, spun a ridiculous excuse, charmed his way out.

But Mydei?

He actually… cared what that bastard thought of him.

Phainon hadn’t looked up since the moment he got hauled into this place, and he sure as hell wasn’t about to start now.

Aglaea, seated beside him, looked completely unbothered. Sipping her tea like she was perched in her favorite garden arbor and not the most feared judgment hall in existence.

Finally, she set the cup down with a pleasant, delicate clink. The sound echoed across marble and stone.

A beat.

Then she spoke, voice silk-wrapped steel.

“Now,” Aglaea said with a faint, not-unkind smile that made Phainon’s stomach sink, “let’s begin, shall we?”

Chapter End Notes

Now that I think abt it, it’s been a while since I updated this huh

Chapter 5: Divine Discomfort

Chapter Summary

> Phainon gets insulted by ancient gods, almost exiled, and saved by Mydei. Aglaea sips tea, schemes, and somehow, Phainon ends up holding hands with Mydei. 10/10 would spiral again.

Chapter Notes

> Short as fuck but I am hustling to finish this soon so I can get on to that Myphai long fic whilst also working on chapter 11 of another fic and doing ANOTHER fic with Flame Reaver getting some atrocious backshots😭
>
> Oh yeah fun fact, this is three of the only ones of my fics I'm too afraid to back read, deadass

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It hadn't started like this.

The Agnostherion—a chamber built into the marrow of the world, where ancient names were unmade and woven into legend—had convened for something important. Something grand. Phainon vaguely remembered Aglaea murmuring about *"matters of celestial order"* while dragging him here by the proverbial ear.

Now?

It was a tribunal.

His.

"How dare a being of your nature desecrate Thalarionis?" one of them spat, voice like shattering ice against marble. A severe figure, all opalescent skin

and hair braided in threads of starlight, glaring down at him from an ivory seat.

Another leaned in, lips curling. *"This is precisely why Incubi should never have been permitted to exist."*

Oh. Well. Damn.

Phainon stood very still, shoulders slumped in something between fatigue and resignation. He kept his eyes forward, careful not to glance at the seat where Mydei sat, radiating a brand of silent fury that was somehow worse than if he'd spoken.

Someone else—a withered thing that looked like it had personally salted the earth after the fall of the Titans—sneered, *"Parasite."*

Tainted familiar.

Lesser breed.

The words hit like pebbles against glass. Small, sharp things. The kind you'd barely register until your skin stung from the accumulation. Phainon wasn't new to this. Gods had never been subtle in their contempt. He just hadn't expected it to be so… *colorful* this early in the day.

Well, this is worse than expected.

His gaze flicked to the grand arched doorway behind him, briefly calculating the distance, the guards, the ceiling height. *If I bolt now… I can probably swim to the surface before they catch me. Fake my death. Change my name. Open a roadside eel stall somewhere deepsea. It wouldn't be the worst plan I've had.*

Another voice chimed in, syrupy-sweet, as if they were doing him a kindness. "Of course, one cannot entirely blame the creature. It is in their nature. That hunger. That filth."

Phainon sighed internally. *Gods, you people are exhausting.*

And this was only the beginning.

A voice older than sand rasped from somewhere near the back. “I never trusted Philemon, not since the incident at the Obsidian Shore.”

A pause.

Phainon blinked. “Who?”

Another decrepit figure, this one looking like the fossilized remains of a half-forgotten war deity, jabbed a gnarled finger in his direction. “You. You’re the one who seduced the entire Monastery of Selene during the Fourth Aeon, aren’t you? Blighted every altar. Disgraced a hundred vows.”

Phainon opened his mouth, then slowly closed it. *What in the hell was that even supposed to mean?*

“Wasn’t me,” he muttered, loud enough for Aglaea to hear. She didn’t so much as blink, delicately sipping her tea.

Another god, hair like coiled mist and eyes that shimmered like a dying star, squinted down at him. “Feanor?”

“I—” Phainon dragged a hand down his face. *“Phainon.”*

At this point, he threw a subtle glance toward the high seat.

Mydei’s expression hadn’t changed. Still sharp, still unreadable. But there was the faintest twitch at the corner of his mouth, somewhere between *‘I’ll kill them all’* and *‘this is why I hate these meetings.’*

Phainon side-eyed him harder. *Are you hearing this?*

He swore, for half a heartbeat, Mydei’s gaze flicked to him—a silent, *‘Of course I’m hearing this.’*

And then right back to stony, simmering silence.

Another ancient god leaned forward. “Are you not one of Echidna’s spawn?”

“What the f—no!”

A strangled noise from the seat beside him. Aglaea coughed delicately into her cup, but Phainon caught the flicker of amusement in her eyes.

Gods. This was going to be a long meeting.

The shift was subtle at first. The usual pompous sneering and mispronunciations bleeding into something crueler.

“I see no reason this…*creature*…should retain the mark of a familiar,” one god announced, voice like cracked marble. “It was a mistake to elevate an Incubi to such standing in the first place.”

A ripple of murmured assent followed. Another, draped in sea-silver cloth, flicked an elegant hand. “Exile would be mercy.”

Phainon stiffened. *Well okay. Guess we’re escalating now.*

“I move for cleansing,” someone else drawled, and the word made his stomach twist. He knew what cleansing meant, and it wasn’t metaphorical.

Okay, he needed to speak now.

Phainon cleared his throat and rose halfway from his seat, managing a polite smile so thin it practically cracked. “With all due respect, venerable ones,” his voice steady but edging toward sharp, “I didn’t desecrate anything. I didn’t seduce any monasteries—recently—and I certainly didn’t blight your godsforsaken altars.”

A low, scandalized murmur.

“I entered on sanctioned grounds, under relic seal. Participated in the rites of Aetheris as per tradition. And, let’s be honest, outperformed half your blessed little champions while doing it.”

Another ripple, this time mixed with outrage.

Aglaea raised a brow over her teacup, clearly impressed.

“Furthermore,” Phainon pressed on, his polite facade straining at the edges, “I have upheld every term of my binding. If my mere existence offends your ancient sensibilities, perhaps you should revisit the laws you wrote yourselves.”

He was panting by the end of it, teeth gritted behind a brittle grin. A cold sweat beading at his temple.

Silence hung heavy.

He darted a glance toward Mydei again, as if silently begging *any time now would be great.*

But the Crown Prince of the Heavens remained where he was, sharp gaze locked on him like a hawk sizing up a particularly reckless hare. Unreadable.

And gods, it burned.

Another voice, low and venomous: “Parasite.”

A second: “Tainted breed.”

Phainon’s jaw twitched. He felt his composure start to fray like overstrained thread.

Just a little longer, he told himself. *Just hold it together.*

But the bile in his throat tasted like old shame and godblood.

The council chamber simmered with tension thick enough to choke on. Another insult dangled in the air, another self-righteous voice drawing breath—when a voice cut through it.

Cold. Low. Absolute.

“He bested your chosen, didn’t he?”

Silence.

The words rolled through the chamber like a chill wave, sinking sharp and deep. Every head turned toward the high dais where Mydei lounged—or rather, sat with the predatory stillness of a blade half-drawn. His hand rested against his cheek, expression the very definition of unimpressed.

One of the elder gods bristled, pride twitching to life. But Mydei’s gaze flicked toward them—a slow, disinterested pass of icy golden eyes.

They went quiet. Sat down.

Phainon, against his better judgment, felt his stomach flip. He knew that look. He knew what followed it. And by the gods, it wasn’t for anyone else’s sake.

“Strange,” Mydei went on, voice all lazy frostbite, “for a ‘lesser creature.’”

A single, sharp-edged pause.

No one spoke. No one so much as breathed.

And just like that—the accusations shrank back. The daggers dulled.

Because if the Crown Prince of the Heavens made a claim, divine law itself bent to it. And whether Mydei admitted it aloud or not, there wasn’t a god in the room who didn’t hear the *mine* in that.

Phainon kept his face neutral. Barely. But inside?

He was already drafting the world’s longest what the actual fuck monologue.

Phainon, in a moment of absolutely unparalleled genius, shot Mydei a thumbs-up.

A literal, dumbass, mortal-style thumbs-up.

Across a divine council chamber.

In front of the assembled gods who quite literally decided the fates of realms.

Mydei's jaw ticked, just a fraction. His fingers drummed once against the arm of his seat like a man contemplating smiting his own houseplant for being endearingly idiotic. His expression didn't flicker, but Phainon *felt* the unimpressed, bone-deep *why by the Gods do I have such a stupid familiar* radiating off him in waves.

But also—and this was the stupid part, really—the unspoken *his* under it.

Mydei wouldn't let anyone else take him. Never had. Never would.

Phainon swallowed. His internal monologue lit up like a funeral pyre.

Holy shit I'm saved.

A beat.

Holy shit that's gonna cost me later.

Because Mydei never forgot a debt. And he collected with interest.

Aglaea, unbothered, set her teacup down with a delicate *clink*, smiling as though none of this had just happened.

"Well," she said brightly, "shall we continue?"

Phainon slumped further into his chair.

By the stars, I should've faked my death when I had the chance.

The atmosphere in the Agnostherion was still sour, but noticeably muted now, like a storm forced to simmer under a watchful sun. Mydei's words had landed like an executioner's blade, and the room knew better than to test the weight of it twice.

A few of the older gods—the ones so ancient even their memories had rusted—grudgingly cleared their throats, muttering half-hearted retractions that didn't fool anyone.

"Perhaps… we spoke in haste."

"A misjudgment… of lineage."

Aglaea, ever the tactician in a silk glove, smiled like she hadn't just witnessed the entire room consider public execution five minutes ago. She folded her hands with effortless poise, voice as smooth as consecrated oil. "Let it be recorded, then, that Phainon, familiar of the Crown Prince, displayed… unexpected prowess. And a unique resilience under divine pressure."

Phainon, who'd been doing his best impression of an inanimate object for the past ten minutes, mentally translated that with a grim little snort.

'Cockroach.' She just called me a cockroach.

He fought the urge to smirk. Mostly because if he cracked a grin now, one of the old bastards would probably keel over from the sheer audacity.

Aglaea gave him a brief, knowing glance.

Mydei remained leaned back in his seat, silent and lethal as ever—but Phainon swore he saw the faintest ghost of a smirk tug at the corner of his mouth.

Just for a moment.

Then it was gone.

The verdict came down like a closing blade.

"He will not be punished here," one of the elder councilors finally conceded, words acidic in his mouth. "His… patron will answer for him."

A few murmurs stirred at that—but no one dared challenge it now.

Mydei, still seated in regal detachment, raised his hand with casual finality. “I’ll take responsibility.”

The council fell silent once more.

Aglaea, amused as ever, started speaking at that moment. “Good. Then this matter is resolved. Recession is called.”

The gathering broke apart like frost under sunlight—gods and ancient familiars rising and vanishing in flashes of light and vapor. Only Mydei remained for a moment longer, before turning without a word and striding out through one of the arching exits.

Phainon didn’t need to be told. The man moved like a storm cloud with a sense of purpose. He trailed after him.

The doors of the Agnostherion closed behind them with a muted thrum.

He barely had time to blink before a hand snatched his arm and yanked him into a narrow side corridor, the divine equivalent of a backstage alley. A solid wall of Mydei loomed over him, golden eyes sharp and unamused.

“What,” Mydei said, voice low and lethal, “were you doing in Thalarionis?”

There wasn’t rage in his tone. Not the kind that would crack marble. It was something else. Concern. The kind that didn’t surface often but hit twice as hard when it did.

Phainon stared up at him, feeling the telltale prickle of heat crawl up his neck. He should’ve expected this. Honestly, he kinda did. What he didn’t expect was how close Mydei had him pinned against the wall, one arm braced just beside his head, their bodies mere inches apart.

“Wow,” Phainon breathed, tilting his head with a grin. “Didn’t know you cared, *Your Highness.”*

Mydei didn’t blink. “I don’t.”

The lie was so barefaced it made Phainon grin wider, despite the fact that his pulse was going haywire in his throat.

“Sure you don’t,” he murmured, eyes half-lidded. “And here I thought you only got this rough when I asked nicely.”

Mydei’s expression didn’t change, but there was a flicker. Something sharp and frustrated in those gilded eyes.

“You could’ve died,” he said flatly. “You *should’ve*, with the Month of Aetheris upon us. Did you forget what happened last time you crossed aether-saturated ground? Or did you just stop caring whether you live through the cycle?”

Phainon faltered for half a second. He hated that. Hated how easily Mydei could carve through all the shit and find the marrow of him.

“I was careful,” he lied.

“You’re a terrible liar.”

“Am not.”

“Are.”

Phainon snorted softly, feeling some of the tension bleed out of him, though his heart was still hammering from… well, everything. He let his head loll back against the wall, a sigh escaping.

“I needed out,” he muttered. “And it was either sneak into a cursed underwater city or let my brain melt outside waiting for you all alone. I took my chances.”

Mydei exhaled, a long-suffering sound, and finally stepped back—not far, but enough for Phainon to breathe properly.

“I should chain you to your quarters.”

“Ooh,” Phainon perked up, trailing after him as Mydei turned and started walking again. “Promises, promises.”

Mydei cast him a deadpan look over one shoulder.

Phainon coughed. “So… about those punishments you mentioned back there—”

“You’ll live,” Mydei said, no inflection, but there was a flash of something in his gaze before he looked away again. A tightness in his jaw. A weight in his posture.

And for a moment, Phainon sobered. Because beneath all the snark and royal irritation, Mydei had been worried. Not for his familiar’s reputation. Not for protocol.

For him.

Phainon let the teasing drop just enough to let that warmth sit in his chest for a moment. Then, because he was who he was:

“Can I at least pick the restraints?”

Mydei kept walking, but the faint twitch at the corner of his mouth was answer enough.

Phainon followed, smiling like an idiot.

The council chamber’s vast doors opened once more, spilling pale celestial light across the marble floor as gods, spirits, and familiars filtered out in murmuring clusters. The air still felt thick with leftover judgment, but no one dared meet Phainon’s gaze now. A few familiars dipped respectful nods to Mydei as he passed, others wisely keeping their heads bowed, the tension of earlier transmuted into wary, grudging deference.

Phainon trailed a few steps behind, still mentally recovering from the fact that he wasn’t exiled, beheaded, or turned into divine lawn fertilizer.

It wasn’t until they crossed the final threshold of the Agnostherion that Mydei slowed, an unreadable look flickering across his face. He stopped just before the threshold of the outer courtyard, golden eyes fixed ahead but something else tightening in his jaw.

Phainon cocked a brow. “What? Don’t tell me you forgot your diadem or something.”

Mydei didn’t answer at first. Then, with a faint exhale, he spoke—voice soft, so only Phainon could hear.

“…Let’s stay a bit longer.”

Phainon blinked. “Wait—what?”

“You wanted to see this place properly, didn’t you?” Mydei kept his gaze forward, tone carefully neutral, but his hand reached out—not the grip from before, no threading of golden light, no pressure. Just a hand, extended, open. Waiting.

Phainon’s heart did a weird little flip. Not because of the offer. Not because the Crown Prince of the Heavens was casually suggesting they loiter in a sanctified divine city like it was no big deal. But because for once, for once, it wasn’t duty or power making the decision.

It was for *him*.

He hesitated half a beat. Then, without his usual teasing quip, he reached out and took Mydei’s hand.

Warm. Steady. Certain.

And like that, the ache in his chest dulled a little. His steps felt lighter.

“Lead the way, Your Highness,” Phainon murmured, voice sardonic but softer than usual.

And together, hand in hand, they walked back into the divine city.

Chapter End Notes

Smut is gonna be next chapter probably? Yeah, 90% sure😍 (Unrelated but ohh my gosh my stomach hurts so bad Take this as a lesson folks, don’t eat like a cow or suffer the consequences like me😭)

Chapter 6: Not Okay, Together

Chapter Summary

> Phainon takes one (1) detour, accidentally wakes up an ancient, semi-sentient court of divine thirst traps, has a minor breakdown, locks himself in his room, and nearly eats his best friend. Mydei heroically ignores personal space, Crown Prince responsibilities, and centuries of emotional repression to kick down the metaphorical door and finally ask if Phainon's okay. He's not. Nobody's okay. But at least they're not okay together now.

Chapter Notes

> Smut is next chapter, I promise It was meant to be here but the chapter got too long and I am EXHAUSTED. I've got like two fic chapters and three essays due, so send me strength.
>
> Also if you wanna scream about these dumbasses, I'm over on Twitter: https://x.com/thelunaeryi?s=21😘

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sanctum of Mydei was less a residence and more a celestial bastion—a place where the heavens folded close and ancient, star-carved halls hummed with a power too old for names. Constellations crawled lazily across the vaulted expanse overhead, shifting with the seasons, their light pooling in pale, opalescent rivers along polished starstone floors.

It wasn't a place most beings visited lightly. And yet, Phainon had his own room, gifted by the Crown prince himself.

Currently, he wasn't in it.

He was somewhere higher—a place where wide, open terraces unfurled like the palm of a sleeping titan, high above the sanctum's inner sanctuaries. It wasn't a roof, because nothing in Celestialis was so mundane. No—this was

a stargazer’s platform, once used by the early court to chart the celestial shifts before mortal astronomy stole half their secrets. The marble here was warm to the touch, veined with lines of liquid silver that pulsed with the seasons.

Phainon lay sprawled across it like a discarded poem, one leg hooked over the side, half-lidded gaze tracking a constellation he didn’t care enough to name.

He was bored.

The kind of thick, damned boredom only immortals could truly appreciate —stretched thin by an eternal afternoon, worn raw by too many days of good behavior. And worse yet, it was still the Month of Aetheris.

He flicked a pebble—or what passed for a pebble here, a tiny shard of crystallized starlight—at a nearby krater resting too elegantly on a ledge it had no business being on. Ancient, hand-thrown, ringed in depictions of battles long since reduced to myths even among their kind.

It struck true.

The vessel tipped with a delicate wobble, then fell. Phainon didn’t even flinch at the shattering sound—a low, musical crack that split the charged air. A beat later, and the scattered fragments slowed, halting mid-air in a shimmer of white-gold light before lazily reassembling themselves. The krater floated back to its ledge as if nothing had happened.

Phainon beamed to himself.

“Still got it.”

He gave a low, satisfied hum and flopped onto his back again, hands laced behind his head. Somewhere deep below, he could sense Mydei moving —a pulse, a flicker of cold radiance in the sanctum’s heart. Probably reviewing decrees or attending to some other infuriatingly responsible task while Phainon wasted away from celestial abstinence.

The thought made his grin widen, though it felt more like a grimace now.

Aetheris. Gods help him.

And it was only getting worse.

He threw an arm over his face to block out the drifting stars, knowing full well he wouldn’t last the night.

Not like this.

Phainon leans back against the sun-warmed stone, the ache beneath his skin constant now. He could feel the month’s pressure gnawing at him, a dull, needling pain he tried to ignore.

What to do, what to do…

The gardens?

He didn’t care much for sentimental flora unless they tried to eat him.

The Archives?

“Absolutely not.”

If he wanted judgmental stares from long-dead names, he’d have stayed in the Agnostherion.

The baths, maybe—

Tempting. But last time he nearly got burned by the water, and the water sprits there…no further comment.

And then it struck him.

The Sunset Vigils.

Quiet. Untouched. Serene. The one place in Celestialis no one badgered him.

Phainon straightened, rolling his neck with a muted crack.

“Perfect.”

He slipped off the ledge, boots ghosting over the marble, the sanctum’s divine light catching in his hair like liquid sun. Hunger still gnawed at him —but for now, it could wait. It always had to wait.

The Sunset Vigils would do.

The halls of Celestialis stretched around him, vast as a world entire. Ceilings soared higher than any mortal mountain, vaulted with sunfire and living starstone. Every step he took echoed against marble older than recorded history, the air thick with the scent of ozone and sun-warmed mineral.

He passed a mural floating midair, its paint rippling like water —a battle long since ended, gods clashing with a horde of nameless things made of shadow and teeth. One of the figures in the mural looked suspiciously like Mydei, young and furious, hurling a star like a spear.

A harp played itself in an alcove, fingers of invisible light plucking notes so mournful even the stone seemed to hum in sympathy. It had been playing that same tune for two centuries. Phainon didn’t know why. Didn’t care either. He gave it a lazy two-fingered salute as he strolled by.

A mosaic of the First Dawn spread across a domed ceiling ahead, a wash of molten gold and bleeding pink, celestial figures rising from the void. Phainon craned his neck to look up at it as he passed —partly admiring the craft, mostly because his back ached like hell and he needed an excuse to stretch.

Divine figures moved through the halls around him. A goddess with stormcloud hair and skin the color of distant lightning inclined her head to him in passing. He offered a smile, half flirt, half challenge. She didn’t bother stopping.

A demigod leaned against a pillar, polishing a celestial spear until it gleamed like a captured sun. The bastard barely gave Phainon a glance, though the corner of his mouth twitched —whether in disdain or irritation, Phainon couldn't tell. He waved anyway.

Then there was that familiar. The one he'd beaten a few weeks back in the duel to avoid suspicion, left flat on the floor and humiliated before a ring of snickering peers. Phainon caught his eye, smirked, and the poor fool immediately looked away, pretending to be absolutely fascinated by the decorative etching of a serpent devouring the sky.

Serves you right, Phainon thought smugly, rolling his shoulders. Here, away from the suffocating holiness of Thalarionis and the Council's venomous stares, he could afford to be a little more himself —sharp-edged, irreverent, and so profoundly done with the gods and their melodrama.

Somewhere ahead, he could already hear the muted chants of the Sunset Vigils. Good. He needed it.

And maybe, if the Fates were merciful, there'd be something worth stealing along the way.

Phainon took a turn where he shouldn't have.

Which, in fairness, wasn't entirely his fault. The paths of here weren't like mortal places, where left was left and down was down. Here, the corridors moved with the seasons, stairs inverted themselves on solstices, and doors led to different realms if you opened them with the wrong hand. It was a place built for gods, and the architecture had no patience for mortals—or half-blood incubi with too much attitude and not enough sense.

He ducked through an archway framed by sun-gold laurels and immediately felt it—the unmistakable pressure of important shit happening. The air hung heavier here, thick with old rites and the weight of converging realms. Voices murmured in a dozen languages at once, and distant bells tolled in time with nothing at all.

A sprawling gallery opened before him, overlooking a confluence of star paths. Figures had gathered in clusters: towering beings cloaked in shifting constellations, envoys made of mist and starlight, high familiars wearing the banners of their patrons. At the center of it all, an obsidian dais rose like a black sun, a ceremonial nexus already alight with glyphs older than death.

Ah. Shit.

The Syzygy Convergence.

Phainon groaned internally, rubbing a hand down his face. Of course it would be this week, that explains all the guests here. The last time this happened—what, three centuries ago?—an entire minor pantheon defected, two archons declared war mid-ceremony, and a pair of sun-gods ran off together. Scandalous stuff. Good times.

But this? This was not his scene. Not unless someone was pouring wine or starting a fight.

He turned on his heel, ready to bolt—but not before a scent caught him. Sweet, heady, sharp as lightning-struck pine. A glimmer of something glinting unattended on a nearby pedestal: a delicate, sun-blessed fruit known to be wildly illegal outside consecrated rites.

Phainon’s mouth watered.

Maybe if I just—

He reached for it.

A pulse of pressure slammed into him like a hammer to the ribs. Not violent—just a casual reminder that he was *very much not supposed to be here.* The kind of ambient holy energy that made his incubi blood crawl and his stomach lurch.

Phainon coughed sharply, stumbling back a step. His skin prickled, breath catching as his bones ached under the weight of it.

“Right, okay, no,” he muttered to himself, throwing his hands up in surrender. “Not worth it. Not dying for a damn plum.”

He slowly pivoted backwards, heading back toward the safe familiarity of the Vigils. The path dimmed behind him as the Convergence’s radiance receded. He could still feel the sting of it in his chest, like someone had dropped a sun down his throat.

And the dumbest part? This was *Mydei’s* realm. He didn’t have to steal anything here. He had a whole room, a set of keys—well, okay, not keys, more like a sigil-ward—and technically full access. He could’ve asked.

He wouldn’t have, obviously. But he *could* have.

Phainon snorted at himself, rubbing his shoulder as he walked. This place was a labyrinth of starstone, moving skies, and the casual kind of sanctity that made his skin itch. And he liked it here. A little too much.

He liked it because it was his. Not officially, not by title or decree—but by virtue of the fact Mydei hadn’t thrown him out yet. And probably wouldn’t.

Not until he did something *really* stupid.

Which, given his track record, could be any minute now.

Whatever, he’ll worry about that later.

Phainon finally reached the Sunset Vigils.

A vast, open expanse carved from ancient starstone, it jutted out into the aether like a balcony to nowhere. Below it stretched the cosmic sea, a vast undulating canvas of light and shadow where constellations rippled like liquid gold, stars blinking in and out of existence like the heartbeat of the heavens. The horizon bled from violet to indigo, soft hues swallowing the sharp lines of the world.

Dais-like seats carved from meteoric stone lined the terrace, their surfaces faintly aglow with a cold, silver sheen. Incense drifted in curling threads from hanging braziers—dusk and myrrh.

And, best of all:

No one else was around.

Phainon let out a long, indulgent sigh, his shoulders finally dropping. Gods, it was perfect. No blustering emissaries, no sanctimonious priests, no overgrown walking suns. Just the dusk, the wind, and the endless sea of stars.

He flopped down onto the dias—uncaring of the faint snap of static energy against his skin—and leaned back with a groan. The stone was cool, almost soothing against the constant ache in his bones.

A rare moment of peace.

For about thirty seconds.

Then it started.

That slow, relentless burn in his chest. His skin prickled, sensitive to every mote of light. The glow in the air felt like glass scraping along his nerves.

Phainon clenched his jaw, squeezing his eyes shut.

Maybe if I just ride it out. One more day. Just a little longer.

He'd managed this long, hadn't he? Sure, his hands shook when he reached for anything in this place, and sure, he felt like he might black out when too much hit him at once—but it wasn't like anyone noticed. Mydei hadn't said anything. And Phainon sure as hell wasn't going to be the one to admit it.

He blew out a slow breath and grumbled to no one, "Dramatic bastards, the lot of 'em."

A constellation overhead blinked, like it agreed.

Damn Month of Aetheris. Damn divine politics. Damn his own stubborn ass for thinking he could tough it out just to…what, prove himself? Outlast it? Be worthy of a god who never asked him to bleed for it?

He groaned and let his head tip back against the starlight, watching the sky ripple overhead.

“Dumbass gods and their self-importance… should’ve been a baker.”

The cosmic sea shimmered in reply.

Phainon let his gaze drift lazily along the curve of the horizon, catching glimpses of floating sanctuaries drifting through the upper reaches—pale, spired structures tethered by chains of silver light, carrying envoys between realms during the Syzygy Convergence. Every so often, one would vanish behind the veil of clouds.

In the distance, a seraphic choir was rehearsing for one of the day’s rites, their voices like glass bells struck by summer wind. It prickled at the edges of his hearing, both beautiful and headache-inducing.

He made a face.

He felt it before he saw him.

A subtle shift in the air, like the crackle of a coming storm. That same pressure that made the skin on the back of his neck prickle, the taste of charged energy thick on his tongue. It was like sensing a wildfire cresting the next hill—not dangerous to him, not really, but impossible to ignore.

And then there he was.

Mydei.

Leaning against one of the starstone pillars, expression caught somewhere between unimpressed and resigned. Dressed in red, sleeveless silks trimmed in muted gold, hair tousled like it always was when he couldn’t be bothered, gaze sharp as a falling blade. The ambient glow of the sanctum bent subtly

around him—the weight of him making the space ripple like heat above a flame.

He exhaled, long-suffering, and crossed the distance in a few measured steps before dropping down onto the bench beside Phainon.

“So this is where you’ve been sulking.”

Phainon grunted without looking at him, gaze fixed on the cosmic sea. “Sulking’s dramatic. I prefer ‘heroically enduring.’”

“Enduring what, precisely? The unbearable burden of not being the loudest one in the room for once?”

“Mm. The oppressive injustice of radiant gods judging me for my unparalleled charm.”

A flicker of something almost resembling a smirk tugged at Mydei’s mouth, though his eyes stayed sharp—assessing. It wasn’t just banter. Phainon could feel the weight of his gaze, the way it lingered too long on the tightness in his jaw, the fine sheen of sweat on his skin despite the cool night air, the way his hand flexed as though to steady himself.

“Phainon.”

He hated how Mydei said his name sometimes.

Phainon cracked a grin that felt too sharp. “What, miss me already?”

Mydei didn’t answer right away. The dusk light caught on the lines of his face, making him look older than his agelessness ever allowed—not weary, exactly, but weathered in a way no one else could see. He tilted his head, watching Phainon in a way that made it hard to breathe.

“You’re overdrawn.”

“Tch. I’ve been worse.”

“That’s not something to brag about.”

“It is if you’ve lived through it.”

Silence stretched between them.

Phainon finally sighed, tipping his head back. “It’s nothing. I can handle it.”

“You shouldn’t have to.”

Another beat of silence.

Phainon snorted, bitter. “You don’t get it.”

Mydei’s gaze didn’t waver. “Then explain it to me.”

But Phainon didn’t. Not yet.

Because it was easier to deflect. To grin like the insufferable bastard he was born to be, and pretend the hollow gnawing inside him wasn’t clawing its way up his throat.

He settled for, “You’re a persistent little storm cloud, you know that?”

“You’re in my sanctum. Don’t tempt me to throw you off the balcony.”

“That’s flirting where I’m from.”

That earned a faint, exasperated sound from Mydei, but not a denial.

And for a moment—just a moment—the ache in Phainon’s chest dulled once again.

Mydei didn’t speak right away, and Phainon felt the shift again—that subtle ripple in the air.

“You didn’t show for the Syzygy.”

Phainon snorted, leaning his head back against the cool stone behind him. “Not exactly my scene. All those sanctimonious pricks posturing for power,

waxing poetic about eternal balance while half of them are plotting how to screw the other half sideways? I'll pass."

A pause. He felt Mydei's gaze still on him. Too piercing, *concerned*.

Phainon sighed. Ran a hand through his hair, fingers snagging in the light strands.

"Alright, fine." The words tasted worse than he expected. "Didn't wanna… embarrass you."

Mydei's brow lifted a fraction, unreadable. "Embarrass me?"

"Yeah, you know." Phainon clicked his tongue, thinking of how to put it. "Not exactly what most picture when they think 'favored familiar of the Crown Prince.' Thought maybe if I stayed scarce, let you shine without the parasite clinging to your heels, it'd make your life easier."

The silence that followed wasn't empty. It was dense. Heavy with things unsaid, things better left unsaid, and things long overdue.

Mydei moved then—not much, just straightened a little, but the shift in his presence was like watching the sky darken.

His voice, when it came, was steady. Measured like the strike of a sword.

"You are my familiar."

Phainon blinked.

"Mine," Mydei repeated, quieter now. "And if anyone in any realm dares imply you aren't worthy of that bond—I'll carve their tongues from their skulls and feed them to something hungry."

A beat.

"Or better yet," he added, almost lazily, though the ardent tone in his voice said otherwise, "you can do it yourself. You'd enjoy it more."

Phainon stared for a moment, then snorted out a sharp, surprised laugh. “Kinky.”

Mydei didn’t flinch. “I’m not joking.”

And he wasn’t.

Phainon could see i, that grim, absolute certainty in Mydei’s gaze. The kind of loyalty that didn’t come with pretty words or gilded oaths, but with sharp edges and the promise of blood.

And for a creature like him, there was nothing in any world more dangerous… or more tempting.

Phainon swallowed hard, his voice a little softer now. “You’re a dangerous man, your highness.”

“You knew what I was when you made the bond.”

“I did,” Phainon murmured. “Still do.”

And gods, if it didn’t make his chest ache in a way no hunger ever had.

The heat of their earlier words lingered in the air between them, but it softened in the quiet that followed. Neither of them spoke for a while, and it was… comfortable. For once.

Phainon let his gaze drift out to the endless expanse before them—the cosmic sea rolling in liquid gold and deep indigos, never ending.

“Mydei,” he murmured after a moment, voice almost a sigh, “your sky’s obscene, you know that?”

Mydei huffed. “Better than the endless dark you nest in.”

“Mm. Debatable.”

The words were nothing, but the quiet proximity meant everything. Their hands brushed once. Then again. Neither pulled away.

Phainon’s fingers shifted, bold and careless as always—but this time, when he let them settle against Mydei’s palm, Mydei didn’t stop him.

Instead, the prince’s fingers curled around his, warm and steady, callused where they had no right to be, considering his title. They stayed like that, wordless, both staring out across the endless sweep of constellations, a pair of dangerous, stubborn creatures pretending for a rare moment to be something softer.

Then it hit.

A pulse in the air—sharp, unsteady, like a string snapping on a lyre. The atmosphere shifted, brittle as cracked glass. Phainon stiffened, a flicker of raw pain arcing through his chest like an old wound split open, though his expression barely changed. Just a blink. A brief twitch of his jaw.

Mydei’s head snapped up. “What was that?”

Phainon gave an excellent performance of casual confusion. “Yeah, what the fuck was that?”

They didn’t have long to wonder.

A figure emerged from one of the side corridors—a young envoy clad in sky-hued armor, breath ragged, a sheen of pale light clinging to his skin. He skidded to a stop a few paces from them and dipped into a hasty bow.

“Highness—apologies. A minor skirmish broke out on the western cusp. One of the celestial tethers destabilized. The wardens are containing it but—”

Mydei’s eyes looked dead. The look he sent the envoy could’ve scoured paint off a temple wall.

“I entrusted half a pantheon’s worth of veterans to manage this convergence,” he said, voice quiet and lethal as a whetted blade. “I assumed I wasn’t presiding over a crèche.”

The envoy paled. “We—we can contain it, your highness. We only thought—”

“Then contain it,” Mydei snapped, standing now, his grip loosening from Phainon’s hand reluctantly. “If you need my direct intervention for a minor tether slip, you’ll need more than a new assignment after this.”

The envoy swallowed hard, bowed again, and all but fled.

Phainon leaned back lazily, though his stomach twisted. The ache was worse now. He wasn’t sure if it was from the instability, the pulse of divine backlash in the air, or the fact that every part of him wanted to drag Mydei back down beside him and keep him there.

“Go on,” he muttered, waving a hand, trying for that causality that didn’t quite land this time. “Your adoring masses need you. I’ll manage.”

Mydei frowned, lingering, studying him. There was something too knowing in his stare.

“I’ll deal with this quickly,” he said at last. “Stay in the sanctum. Rest. And for once,” his gaze narrowed pointedly, “don’t cause a scene.”

“Wouldn’t dream of it.”

“Phainon.”

“What?”

“I mean it.”

“I’ll be good,” Phainon said, throwing up his hands in mock surrender, though his pulse still pounded unpleasantly under his skin.

Mydei held his stare a moment longer, as though contemplating something. Then he turned, his silhouette breaking into a cascade of light, leaving behind only the lingering scent of dusk-warmed marble and incense.

Phainon let his head fall back against the pillar and closed his eyes.

“Yeah,” he muttered to the empty air. “I’m definitely not going to be good.”

Left alone, Phainon let out a slow breath, dragging a hand through his hair like the motion might chase off the ache gnawing at him from the inside out. It didn’t. The air still hummed faintly from whatever celestial tantrum had just ruptured across the firmament, but that wasn’t the problem.

It was him.

It had been him for days. Weeks.

He groaned under his breath, head tipping back. Nearby, a shallow dish sat on a low pedestal—some divine offering, no doubt intended for pious dignitaries or long-dead heroes still waiting on their commemorative title. In it, slices of preserved star-fruit shimmered faintly, each piece veined with thin threads of liquid silver.

Well, fuck it.

He snagged a piece between two fingers, bit down a little too hard. Sweet. Sharp. It burned faintly as it went down, leaving a taste like sugared lightning across his tongue.

Didn’t help.

Of course it didn’t.

He grabbed another, more out of spite than anything else—a petty, childish gesture, like that one time he’d chugged ambrosia straight from the decanter during a famine season and blacked out for three days. A distraction. A rebellion against the gnawing emptiness curling under his ribs and the static itch beneath his skin.

Phainon chewed absently, gaze fixed on the horizon. Distant planets shifted, bent, rippling like liquid—the kind of sight that would’ve left mortals weeping and poets insufferable. To him, it just looked like another far-off problem some poor courtier was scrambling to keep contained.

His stomach twisted again—not from the fruit.

From everything else.

“What the fuck am I doing,” he muttered, to no one.

There was, of course, no answer.

The worst part wasn’t the ache.

It was the other thing. The softer, worse thing.

The way he kept thinking about him.

Phainon groaned again and shoved himself upright, wincing at the sharp crackle beneath his skin, the pull of emptiness clawing down his spine. No one was around to see the tremor in his fingers as he braced them on his thighs, no one to clock the way his breath stuttered, just once.

Fine. He’d go to his room.

Rot there like the tragic cliché he was apparently becoming while Mydei played diplomat to a court of cosmic toddlers.

Decision made, Phainon turned on his heel, grabbing one more slice of whatever-the-hell divine fruit for the road. Might as well. If the realm was going to kill him, it could at least feed him on the way out.

And that was the thing about Mydei’s sanctum—a stronghold carved from starstone and blood, decked in impossible light and skies that moved when no one was looking.

It let you fall apart in absolute, unapologetic style.

He didn’t quite make it to his room.

The halls twisted in lazy spirals, corridors unfurling like silk ribbons in the dark. Phainon barely registered the turn his feet took, too dulled by hunger to bother correcting course.

It wasn’t until a pulse slid along his senses—sharp, wrong, and gone too quick—that his steps slowed.

He blinked, straightening, frowning into the hush. The place was ancient, its bones older than the gods themselves if the songs could be trusted. It breathed, sometimes. Shifted. Let its thresholds move like drifting tides. But this… this wasn’t the usual groaning of restless foundations or the static haze of converging ley-lines.

This was something waking.

Phainon huffed out a sigh, dragging a hand down his face. “For fuck’s sake,” he muttered, voice gravel against the velvet dark. “He tells me not to cause a scene and then leaves me with this.”

But it was his home, too. In all its impossible, gilded vastness—this realm of Mydei’s—it had cradled his worse nights and stitched his broken pieces together more than once. He wasn’t about to let some half-assed tremor slip by without a look.

He veered left. Down a corridor where the torches guttered in shades of blue and violet, their flames licking at the air like restless tongues. The further he went, the thicker the air felt—not oppressive, but stretched.

The pulse came again.

Faint.

“Alright, alright,” Phainon grumbled, stretching his arms as he moved. “Let’s see what you’re about.”

It led him deeper. Past vaults of sealed antiques, rooms whose names had been forgotten before the earth cooled. At some point, the sanctum’s elegant geometry frayed, corridors breaking into strange, slanted pathways that coiled back on themselves. It wasn’t disorienting to him—the place had always bent a little easier for his tread. But the sense of wrongness gnawed sharp at his nerves.

Eventually, the path outpaced his patience.

The next ledge broke into open air—a drop into one of the lower terraces. Phainon didn't hesitate. He vaulted over the edge, catching a hanging arch with one hand, shoes skimming a sun disc's rim as he swung down. A series of shallow landings spiraled below, and he dropped through them with ease—a flick of movement here, a reckless bound there, until the pulse in the air thickened and drew him toward another archway half-concealed behind a sweep of golden tendrils.

It was old.

One of the Syzygy Gates—high arched, carved with runes he couldn't read. A construct meant to link realms during the great convergences, when the veils between worlds thinned like gold leaf under a knife. This one should've been dead, sealed by god knows who, left to gather dust and moss in its cradle of stone.

But here it was.

Flickering.

Not fully active, but not fully dormant either. A thin line of argent luminescence hummed along the curve of its frame, like a half-drawn breath.

"Well, shit."

Phainon scrubbed a hand through his hair, the glow from the gate painting pale streaks across his skin. He could leave it. Should leave it. Some overeager legate probably fumbled a containment ward. It would fizzle out once the convergence waned, no harm done.

Except…

His gaze snagged on the passage beside it. A connecting space—not a chamber, but one of the Hypourania Courts. A liminal place between thresholds, where the oldest of the sanctum's powers once gathered to

broker pacts and blood-oaths. He'd heard about them, sure. Mydei mentioned them in passing once, dismissing them as relics of a bloodier age. Most were sealed, their entrances bricked over with starstone, threads of ancient law binding their thresholds.

This one wasn't.

A thin seam of shadow cut along its frame, a sliver of space just wide enough for a reckless, half-delirious bastard to slip through.

Which he did.

Because of course he did.

The air inside tasted different. Cooler. It smelled like hollowed-out altars, the ghost of burnt offerings clinging to the walls. The floor was inlaid with patterns—lines of silver, arcs of obsidian dust, constellations carved into the stone beneath his feet.

Phainon paused, a flicker of unease crawling along his ribs.

"Okay," he said to the dark, voice low. "If something in here plans on chewing on my spleen, now's your chance."

No answer.

He moved forward.

And what little light there was coalesced ahead—a distant, hovering glow, tangled in the roots of some ancient sigil, half-erased but still seething. The convergence had stirred it. Drawn thin cracks in the old seals.

Phainon cocked his head, watching the light throb against the dark like a dying ember. He didn't know what it was. Didn't especially want to know.

But he was already here.

And it wasn't like anyone was watching.

He made his way through the gloom, boots scuffing against mosaic patterns. Fragments of scripture curled along the walls, half-devoured by creeping roots. He moved like a shadow through it, every bone in his body tensed, throat dry, pulse a slow, leaden drum.

It was the mirror that stopped him.

Not a mirror, not really. Just a basin of viscous, silvery ichor, thick as liquid moonlight. The surface churned without wind, reflecting nothing until one dared to look.

Once, the immortals stared into these depths, before they forged their heavens and chained their own wildness. They looked upon the thing no worshiper was meant to see.

Phainon caught a flicker of movement, his own reflection snagging on the ichor's restless gleam.

And what stared back wasn't him.

Not as he was.

The thing in the ichor was gaunt, ravenous, eyes bright with a starved, sharp hunger that no wine or violence or careless kiss could slake. Its lips pulled back from bloodstained teeth in something too close to a grin. Its throat worked as if swallowing something thick and hot. A dozen smears of stolen touch, of fire, of iron tang and salt sweat clung to its skin like war paint.

It mouthed something.

He didn't catch it. Didn't want to.

Phainon whistled low, like one does to an animal too dangerous to startle. But his hand gripped the edge of the basin, fingers white-knuckled on cold stone.

Don't look at me like that.

He told it nothing.

It didn’t matter. The Court was listening.

He forced himself to straighten, tried to shake the heaviness from his limbs, muttering some half-hearted curse about Mydei’s insufferable taste in décor as he turned—and saw it.

A fragment.

Leaning against a toppled column of veined marble, half-buried in dust and crumbling silk. A shard of crystal—not much larger than a palm’s width, but the moment his gaze caught it, a pulse bloomed sharp behind his eyes.

The Erotheion Lens.

The resonance gave it away before his eyes did. Not a weapon—a vessel of longing, wrought to transmute lust into covenant. This was a lens made for rites where sovereigns and gods spilled themselves into one another beneath a darkened sky. It did not merely reflect desire. It bore it aloft. And though fractured by time and the trembling of the convergence, its pulse still clung to him like a lover’s touch.

It recognized him.

The moment Phainon stepped near, the fragment flared.

A pulse—a sickeningly sweet *ache* that sank straight through his ribs and coiled tight around the meat of him. It wasn’t a feeling. It was a *bite*. A hook driven beneath his sternum, dragging something raw and bleeding into the open.

And before he could brace, his restraint—brittle, overdrawn, already fraying since Aetheris began—*snapped*.

It wasn’t a clean break. It was a *void*. A yawning, lightless, marrow-deep hunger that swallowed him whole.

It hit like a rupture, like his insides turned inside out. His stomach clenched, breath stuttered, vision searing sharp and bright, then dim. Not just for blood. Not just for touch. Not even for Mydei, though gods, the thought of

him—sun-warm, eyes like stormbreak, the pale line of his throat bared without knowing—burned through Phainon's mind so violently it left him unsteady.

No. It was for *everything*.

For divinity. For ruin. For the ache of flesh under his palm. For the weight of a soul dragged screaming from its shell. For the taste of iron, the press of skin, the crash of a name torn from a throat. For worship. For desecration. Holy and profane. Beautiful and *defiled.*

His knees nearly gave. A dry sound cracked from his throat.

"—no."

But the Court heard him.

The damn thing was *alive*. And it was starving.

For the ache in his marrow, for the black curl of need, for the thing gnashing beneath his tongue every time he bit it down. It unspooled every brittle wall he'd raised, peeled them back like wet parchment, left his hungers naked, thrashing.

His reflection in the ichor twisted, grinned.

He felt his hand tremble. Clenched his fist tight enough for nails to bite skin.

"Stop." The word barely made it out. A rasp, a plea, a command.

The Court *thrummed.* It wasn't going to let him leave standing.

And he felt it. If he lingered, even a heartbeat longer, it would strip him bare. Leave him some howling, hollow thing, a creature of want and nothing else.

He swayed, breath ragged, the world tilting in hot, colorless waves.

He hadn’t meant to come here. Hadn’t meant to wake it. Hadn’t meant to turn himself inside out on ancient teeth.

But it was done.

Now or never.

Phainon tore himself away.

It wasn’t graceful. His body moved before his mind could catch up—staggering back from the ichor’s surface, from the Lens’ cracked glow, from the grasping ache of the Court’s pulse.

He didn’t remember the door. Only the sensation under his palm as he shoved past the cold threshold, the feeling of the place watching him, a low, mocking hum beneath his ribs.

The Hypourania Courts felt amused.

Like something vast and ravenous had cracked open one lidded eye, seen him laid bare, and found the sight *laughable*.

By the time he reached the outer passage, his breath was ragged, his skin clammy. The light of the Celestialis—so soft and sacred on better days—hit like knives, every gleam and glimmer searing too bright against his eyes. The air smelled too sharp, too sweet, cloying with incense and sun-warmed stone, the heady perfume of immortals and old rites clinging to him like a second skin.

His pace faltered.

Phainon pitched sideways, shoulder hitting a column. His vision ghosted at the edges, his pulse a drumbeat in his skull. He brought his wrist to his mouth, bit down hard, teeth breaking skin, copper blooming hot and metallic on his tongue. The pain barely cut through.

It didn’t ground him.

It only reminded him how *close* it had gotten.

Blood welled, smeared over his palm as he pushed off the column, not sparing a glance for the figure or two that might've turned their heads. He didn't care. He couldn't. Every shape blurred into the same too-sharp smear of color and heat. The Celestialis itself felt like it was pressing in, narrow and endless at once, the air thickening with every step.

His pace stuttered, then picked up.

He didn't remember choosing to run, but his legs moved on their own—desperate, fevered, an animal in retreat. And the farther he fled, the deeper the itch in his bones crawled, like the Court's pulse had left a handprint beneath his skin.

He was *wrong*. He'd made a mistake.

A bad one.

He reached his chambers in a blur of half-sensed turns and blurred thresholds, the world around him a smear of too-sharp light and cloying air. The door was an arch of sigil-burnt stone, and he shoved it shut with the full weight of his body. The wards flared, ancient seals threading through the air like spun glass, latching into place with a soundless finality.

The moment the last tether cinched tight, it hit him.

No courtly mask, no feigned composure, no thin, aching restraint. The thing inside him—old, hungering, wrought of silk and thorn and flesh's darker wants—surged to the surface like a wave breaking over a drowning man.

His skin burned. Flushed fever-warm, fever-wrong. His pulse a frantic, shuddering drum against his ribs. Breath hitched, sharp, shallow, ragged. Sweat clung to him, salt and heat and something acrid beneath it. His pupils, already dark, blew wide, swallowing the world. Teeth ached in his skull—too sharp, too eager. His mouth was dry and slick all at once.

Every breath tasted like the Courts. Like ichor and desire and blood-warm air.

He staggered, palm catching the nearest wall, a growl ghosting his lips.

He was fine.

Totally fine.

This was—*part of the plan*. A calculated risk. He'd… he'd accounted for this.

Phainon muttered it like a mantra, half-mad as he tore at his collar, the clasps refusing him for a heartbeat before giving way. His skin felt too tight, every breath like knives. Cold water burned. Warm scalded. Nothing soothed. He gripped the basin's edge until his knuckles whitened, splashing water over his face that steamed on contact, hissing as it met fevered flesh.

"You're fine," he rasped, voice cracking. "Just… ride it out. It'll pass."

But it didn't.

Mydei's face bled through his mind unbidden—the impossible softness of him, thunderlight catching in his eyes, the way his throat bared without fear. Hands around Phainon's wrists like shackles made of grace.

He made a ragged sound, half a laugh, half a snarl.

Something moved in the reflection.

Not him.

Or rather—him, but *other*. Eyes like wells, mouth curling in a knowing, cruel slant.

"Hungry, little incubi?"

The voice wasn't his own.

Phainon lunged. Fist through glass, or what passed for it. The surface shattered in a burst of lightless shards, the voice shattering with it. Ichor-light bled from the break.

Breathing hard, hand bloodied, he pressed his forehead to the stone.

He was fine.

He was fine.

He was so completely, irreversibly, *fucked*.

The hours after were a blur. Phainon barely remembered how he got from the broken reflection to his bed—if you could call it that. More a ruin of silken sheets now, bloodied where his knuckles split, sweat-damp, twisted around his limbs like some half-hearted shroud.

He'd buried himself in it, trembling in the aftermath, skin flushed and fevered, pulse a hammerbeat in his throat. Every nerve felt flayed raw.

And then—

"Phainon."

A sharp knock. A voice he knew too well.

"If you don't let me in, I swear by every star in your rotten veins, I'm breaking this fucking door down."

Phainon groaned, dragging a hand down his face. Of course. *Of course.*

"Mydei…" he croaked, half-muffled in a pillow. "Go away. I'm… meditating."

"You're full of shit."

Another hard knock. Phainon winced.

"I'm fine," he tried, though it came out more like a pained whimper.

"Yeah, you're so *fine* you barricaded your chambers and sent half the realm's wards into a panic," Mydei shot back, exasperated. "I *felt* what

happened in the Hypourania Courts, you idiot. Did you really think you could pull whatever that was and I wouldn't notice?"

Phainon rolled onto his side, burying his face deeper into the twisted sheets. Gods, even Mydei's voice made his skin prickle.

"Seriously, you don't want to be in here right now," he ground out. "I'm… it's bad, Mydei."

A pause. Then, softer: "I know."

Phainon cursed under his breath.

He could imagine the look on Mydei's face—somewhere between murder and worry. It made something in his chest hurt.

"Just give me… a minute. Or an hour. Or a decade."

"Phainon."

"Not helping."

He could practically *hear* Mydei crossing his arms through the door.

A beat passed. Then, lightly: "You're an idiot."

Phainon let out a ragged laugh despite himself, scrubbing at his face.

"Yeah," he muttered, closing his eyes, trying—failing—to slow his heartbeat. "I know."

And because he had no strength left for dignity, he sighed and sank deeper into the mess of pillows and sheets.

"…Don't come in yet though, seriously. I might actually devour you."

"Noted."

But Mydei didn't leave. Just leaned against the door, waiting.

Phainon hated how much comfort that brought.

"…You shouldn't have come."

Outside, a beat of silence.

Then, steady as a vow, "I always do."

Phainon let out a breath. He should've left it there. Let the moment pass, let Mydei's stubbornness settle like it always did. But the ache in his ribs twisted sharp, and a sound slipped from his throat—not quite a curse, not quite a whimper, but unmistakably pain.

The silence shattered.

"Mydei—wait, it's fine—"

"Phainon."

The name was no longer a gentle tether, it was a snapped thread.

Then came the pressure—a ripple through the wards, the ancient seals set by his own hand. The sanctum shuddered under it, light fracturing along the archways, the sigils burning briefly gold.

Even *here*, even behind every layer of Incubi-spun barriers and possession wards, Mydei's will pressed against his own like a rising tide.

Phainon flinched, teeth gritting as another wave of ache surged through him.

"Don't." he rasped. "It's locked for a reason, Mydei."

"I gave you patience," Mydei's voice wasn't angry, but it carried the steady authority of one born to command. "I gave you mercy."

The seals hissed against the strain. A second longer and he'd speak the words that would undo them, would bind Phainon's will to his own, as was his right here in the Celestialis.

Phainon, delirious or not, knew it the moment it started—the old invocation rising in Mydei's voice.

"I give you a *command*—"

"Wait, wait!" Phainon croaked, a rough, breathless laugh breaking through as he curled tighter against the ache in his belly. "That's cheating, Mydei."

A beat. Then the weight at the door stilled—not gone, but balanced, held on the edge of yielding.

"Then open it yourself," Mydei said, quieter now, but no less unmovable. "Or I *will*."

Phainon let his head fall back against the pillows, half laughing, half sobbing.

"You're impossible."

"I've heard," Mydei murmured, and if there was fondness in it, Phainon didn't have the strength to shove it away.

Another long breath. Another crack in the walls he'd built.

"Don't—" Phainon started, then faltered, pressing his hand over his chest where the hunger still clawed. "It's… worse than before."

"I know," came the reply. "I felt it."

A pause. Even a Crown Prince had to bleed to breach a sanctum like this—but Mydei was already halfway there, and Phainon could feel the bond between them humming tight and thin.

"Let me in, Phainon."

Phainon swallowed hard.

"I shouldn't," he whispered.

“I didn’t ask if you should.”

The final wards buckled, seals cracking like brittle bone under the weight of the Crown Prince’s will. A rush of incense-thick air met Mydei as he crossed the threshold—as though the room itself mourned its master’s state.

He stepped through like strength given flesh, eyes sharp, mantle burning faintly at his shoulders. And then —

He saw him.

Phainon lay tangled in sweat-damp sheets, blood staining the linen, his skin flushed and too pale by turns, hair clinging to his brow, throat marked where his own nails had scratched. A creature unmade by his own hungers.

And in an instant, every ounce of princely detachment left Mydei’s face.

He was at the bedside before the thought had finished forming, the heavy fall of his robes pooling around him as he dropped to his knees, a hand already cupping Phainon’s cheek, thumb brushing against burning skin.

“Phainon…” Mydei’s voice cracked low with it—frustration and fear and something else.

“I *told* you,” Mydei muttered, the anger brittle, made of care. “I told you to stay out of trouble, I told you this would happen—”

Phainon laughed—a hoarse, broken sound. “Yeah, well…” he rasped, head lolling against the pillow, half-dazed, half-miserable. “I’ve always been shit at listening.”

And then, as though the heat in his chest had turned his tongue reckless, the words slipped.

“It was easier before you.”

The moment hung, heavy and terrible. Phainon’s eyes squeezed shut, breath ragged. “Forget it. Ignore me. Gods, just—just forget it.”

But Mydei didn’t move.

A beat. Then, softer than it should’ve been, “No.”

His thumb brushed the corner of Phainon’s mouth, eyes still fixed on his face, unwavering.

“I’m listening.”

Phainon let out a sound—sharp, wrecked, half a laugh, half a breath like a sob. His fingers dug into his own arms as though he could hold himself together by force. Mydei’s hand was still there, warm against his jaw, and it burned.

He should’ve pulled away.

He should’ve told him to leave.

But the words wouldn’t come out. Not the ones he was supposed to say.

Instead what came was:

“You don’t know what it’s like,” Phainon spat, voice hoarse. “You—you *can’t*. You wake up every morning and the world fucking belongs to you. The sun sings for you, the storms clear for you, the gods bend for you. You get to be righteous, you get to be *good*.”

His throat worked around a bitter, broken laugh.

“And me? I wake up hungry. Every. Fucking. Day. Wanting things I shouldn’t, craving things that make the everyone flinch. And I choke it down. I bury it. I play nice, and I smile, and I let them laugh like I’m some —some *harmless pretty thing* and I *let them*, because if I don’t, they’ll see me for what I am.”

He sucked in a breath, ragged, his voice cracking on the next words.

“I didn’t ask to be this. I didn’t ask to want like this. I didn’t ask to have to crawl through every day pretending I don’t wanna tear the world apart just

to feel *full* for once.”

His vision blurred, chest heaving like his ribs would split apart. He pressed his palm hard against his sternum, trying to push it all back down, but it was too late.

“And I—” his voice dropped to a choked whisper, eyes flicking up to Mydei’s. “I wanted you to see me. And I hate you for it. Because you did. And now you’re here and I—”

He cut himself off, shaking his head, a forced sigh breaking over. “Gods. Just—just fucking ignore me. I didn’t mean it. None of it. Just… go.”

Mydei didn’t speak at first.

For a beat, he just stared—as if Phainon’s words had knocked the breath from him, left something hairline-cracked behind his steady gaze. His mouth parted, then closed again, a dozen replies stifling themselves at the back of his throat.

And then—softer than Phainon would’ve expected—Mydei’s voice broke the air between them.

“…I didn’t know,” he murmured, and it wasn’t a defense. It sounded like an admission. A failure. His hand lifted, hesitated in the space between them, fingers curling once like he wasn’t sure if he was allowed. Then—slowly, carefully—he let his palm rest against the side of Phainon’s neck, a tether, not a chain.

“I didn’t… I should’ve seen it,” Mydei said, his voice catching on the words, guilt pooling in the spaces between them. “I thought—” He cut himself off, shaking his head, a humorless huff of breath leaving him. “I didn’t stop to think. I just told myself you were fine—because you always act like you are. And I let that be enough.”

He swallowed hard, his thumb brushing against Phainon’s skin like he could smooth the ache away.

“And that was easier for me.”

A breath hung between them. The quiet kind of ache.

“I’m sorry,” Mydei said at last. Not loud, not grand, but raw. Honest. “I’m sorry I left you to deal with this on your own. For not seeing it. For not asking when I should’ve.”

His hand tightened at Phainon’s nape, grounding him in place as if anchoring them both.

“I should’ve known,” Mydei whispered, voice thick. “And if it’s not too late—I’m here now.”

Phainon made a sound then—small, splintered, barely a breath—and Mydei inched closer, their foreheads nearly brushing, the air between them charged and trembling.

“I’m not leaving,” Mydei said, lower now. A promise. A quiet, breaking vow. “You don’t have to preten. Not with me.”

Phainon’s face crumpled. His body shuddered, his hands fisting in the fabric at his knees like he could stop the unraveling, but it was too late. The dam broke.

And this time, when he tipped forward, burying his face in the crook of Mydei’s shoulder, Mydei caught him.

Held him like something precious.

Like something long overdue.

Chapter End Notes

(Rushed, sorry abt that) Lord have mercy on me and my hands, I hate essays😔 anyway how do we feel abt 3.3 though? I would write sm for

it but I literally have no idea what to do so UHHH, ff writers lock in 😍

End Notes

So what’s your thoughts on this so far? This might have been the hardest thing I’ve written, because I deleted 3 different outlines because I couldn’t decide if I wanted sm with plot, or mostly smut, or what type of au I wanted with it.

In the end I got stuck between average joe Mydei with debt collector Incubi Phainon or Crown Prince of Heaven Mydei with Incubi familiar Phainon. I chose the latter, obviously.

Anyway, thanks for reading <333

Works inspired by this one

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